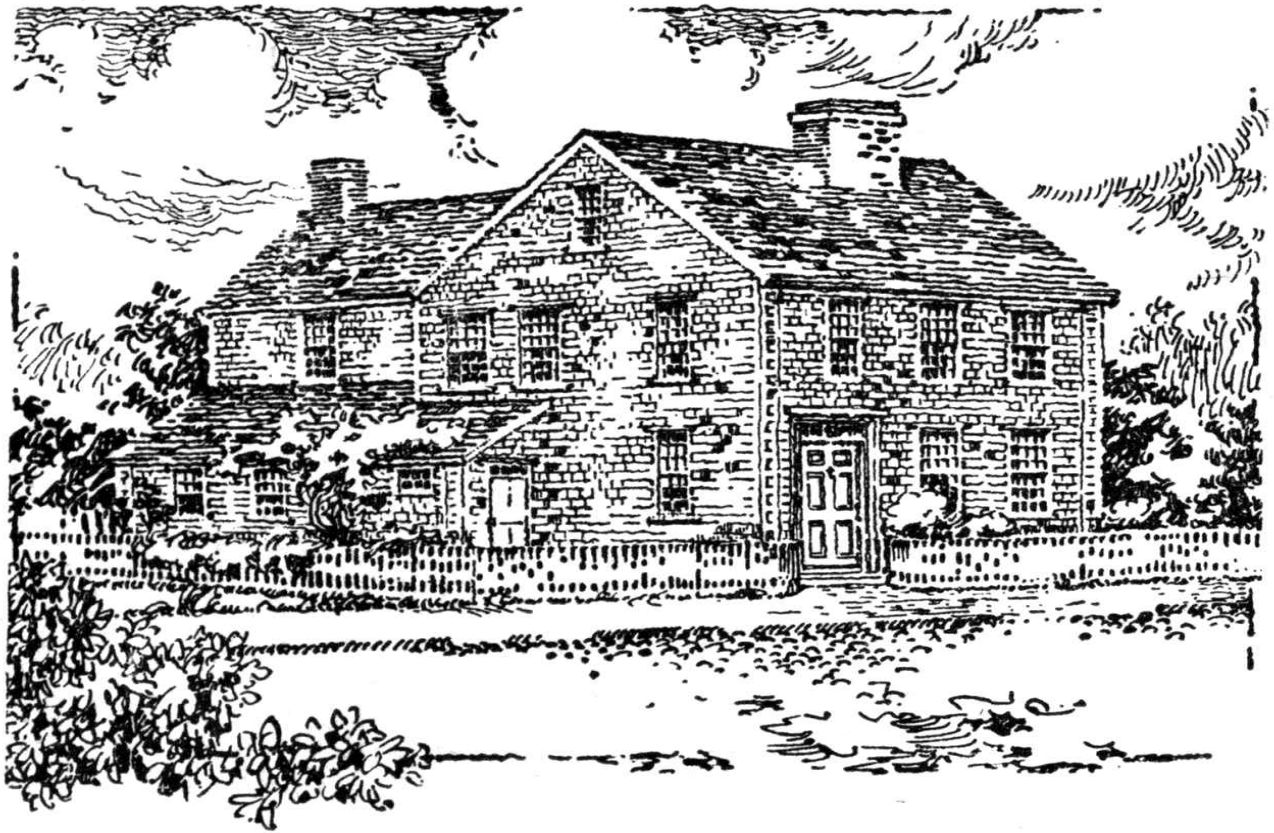
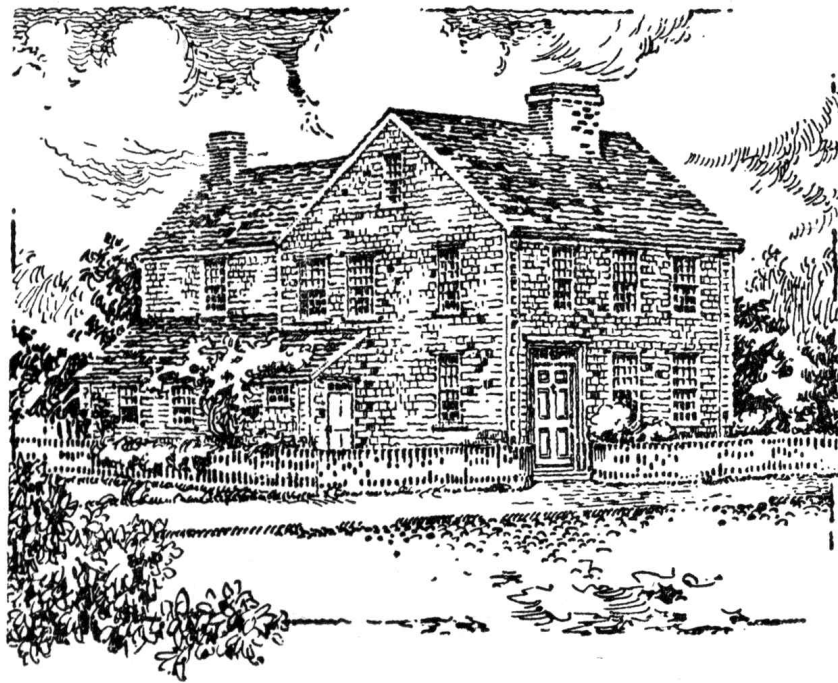


²²
NINETY FIVE
PER CENT PERFECT⁹⁹



²²
NINETY FIVE
PER CENT PERFECT⁹⁹



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Title: "95% perfect"

The older residences at Nantucket

Author: Everett Uberto Crosby

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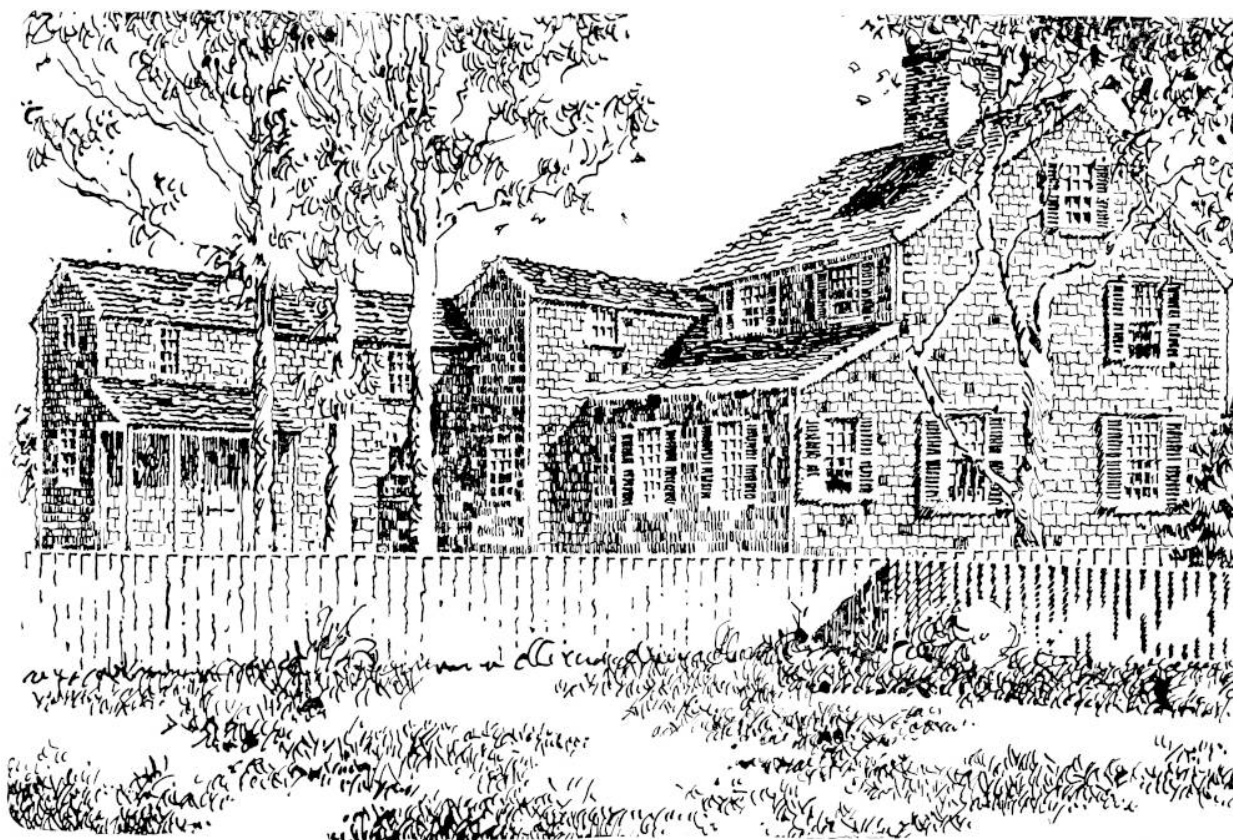
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Characteristic Rear Ells and Lean-to

“95 % PERFECT”

The Older Residences
at
Nantucket

Viewed and Analyzed
by
Everett U. Crosby

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BY

EVERETT U. CROSBY

PREFACE

This book is dedicated to those who assist in keeping unmarred, the old Nantucket dwellings.

Its object is to be of assistance to that end.

The drawings are by Mr. Alfred Shurrocks, photographs by the Piviroto Studio, the printing by The Inquirer and Mirror Press—all of Nantucket Island, Massachusetts.

The following organizations, while in no way responsible for the preparation of the book, or for the subject matter in it, wish to be herein recorded as in sympathy with a continued movement to preserve the architecture of old Nantucket in every possible detail:

Nantucket Historical Association, Chas. E. Congdon, Pres.

Nantucket Civic League, William L. Mather, Pres.

Nantucket Plant Guild, Mrs. William Wallace, Vice Pres.

The Winter Club, Fred V. Fuller, Sec.

E. U. C.

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1801—Josiah Quincy

1807—Anonymous

1811—Joseph Sansom; The Portfolio, Phila.

1850 (before and after)—Joseph E. C. Farnham: Memories of
Boyhood Days on Nantucket.

1876—S. A. Drake: Nooks and Corners of the New England
Coast.

1882—E. K. Godfrey

1924—Walter Prichard Eaton

75. Chimneys, Old and New: From a painting by Kwiseiki
Sadakata.

“95% PERFECT”

This phrase was used by a writer several decades ago to describe the dwelling house architecture of the old town of Nantucket, and since then has been generally accepted. It symbolizes the state of mind of most people who come to this remote island town, traverse its streets and view its houses. They all sense that there is something in the mass or total of dwelling houses that is different from what they are accustomed to elsewhere. The effect is pervading, pleasing and peaceful. It causes them to picture a town of years ago remaining unchanged by the march of time.

Many of us instinctively realize in part the causes of this strong and lasting impression.

First—The dwellings are mostly located close to the street, often directly on the edge of the sidewalk. They are not set back with yards or lawns in front.

Second—The breadth of the house usually occupies much of the lot so that adjacent houses are but a few feet, often a few inches, apart. The gardens, as well as the flapping clothes lines, the additions and the extensions, are at the rear; usually out of sight from the street. These rear (and side) ell and projections are a general characteristic of the old houses. Similar new additions if done in the proper way, with gable roofs or lean-to roofs, can be most pleasing.

Third—Uniformity in architectural type, style, material and colors, within a limited range, is quite general and more responsible than any other single feature for the exceptional and unique ensemble. Elsewhere, in the off-islander's hometown, each block or section is apt to have a medley of types, perhaps in close proximity—as an original colonial house and in succession a bungalow, a mid-Victorian and then a Georgian mansion, a gingerbread pattern house of the 1880 period, followed by a woman's magazine suburban type, and perhaps many others. Each may be very good

of its kind and suit the taste of its owner and belong in certain places. But the appeal at Nantucket is in not having enough of these varying styles to spoil the picture; hardly enough to mar it, in the old part of the town.

PERIODS

The architecture of the dwellings of Nantucket may be divided into three periods:

The English mode of the settlers. This is the early Colonial; the lean-to type. Say, from the time of building the first houses up to about 1740.

The next arbitrary division is the architecture of the Colonial and early Federal times, approximately, as far as Nantucket is concerned, dating from prior to the Revolutionary War to about 1830. Most of our old dwellings belong in this division.

Finally, the Classic period. Commencing about 1830 and continuing to about 1860, after which there was not much building of consequence of any dwellings which need to be considered here.

DOING OVER OLD HOUSES

Each year people from off-island, yielding to the lure of Nantucket, buy old houses, or occasionally build new ones, for seasonal occupancy. For many such the season is lengthening year by year. The spring and fall are glorious in this island climate. The diversions and occupations many and amply absorbing.

Such people almost invariably want an “old” house. From an investment viewpoint alone an old or old-style house sells or rents much more readily and for higher prices than a modern-type structure. Many prospective customers will not look at the latter.

There is a surprisingly large number of competent local carpenter-builders, masons, painters, plumbers and electricians resident on the Island. They can undertake and properly execute practically any work that is likely to be specified. Many of them are glad to assist in carrying out the old Nantucket traditions, but there have been some who frankly had no love for the old; building a house for themselves they would abandon every old feature; there have been a few with very unique ideas of what they call “antique;” so it is essential that strict care be exercised in making additions or building new structures to see that the right designs and details are both adopted and executed.

How can this much desired end be accomplished? It has been suggested that an illustrated book with simple analysis and exposition of this subject would help. This book is an endeavor to be of such assistance.

ANALYSIS

We herein concern ourselves only with the visible exteriors of dwelling houses as viewed from the street. The interiors of the houses and their furnishings are not treated; nor shops nor public buildings. It will be apparent also that this is not written for the architects, particularly those experienced in Nantucket traditions (there are such).

We will not make the customary historical approach to our subject. It would over-emphasize what is not the primary purpose. Thus we are not concerned with the following:

The temporary shelters built at Madaket about 1659.

The houses of the very first town. These were located at and in the vicinity of Capaum Harbour (now Pond) and Hummock Pond, on the north shore about one and a half miles from the present town. Only one, a lean-to type, remains.

Such of these houses or portions thereof which were taken down and removed to what is now the town of Nantucket.

The oldest remaining house, a lean-to dated 1686.

The one brick of the last quarter of the 18th century on Orange Street.

The seven brick houses of the second quarter of the 19th century with parapet brick end gables (six on Main Street and one on Pleasant Street). Also a number of large houses or mansions of about the same period built of wood.

The two of temple columned type on Main Street.

The one classical type on Orange Street.

These houses are the frosting on the cake but they are not the cake.

They are all of great interest and will be viewed later herein, but they are too few to constitute the picture of Nantucket town as a whole, which consists of about 400 old houses.

Then what are the kinds of houses which do constitute our old Nantucket? To find out, we have taken a census which analyzes each house on all or much of the length of most of the streets in the old sections, viz.: Union, Main to Flora; Orange, Main to Lyon; Fair, the entire length; Pleasant, Main to and including Moors End; Middle Main, Fair to the Monument; Upper Main, Monument to head of the street; Gardner, Main to Liberty; Liberty, near Centre to Gardner; Pearl, near Centre to North Liberty; Centre, Gay to West Chester; Lily, Centre to North Liberty; Academy Lane, Centre to Westminster; Gay, Centre to Westminster; Hussey, Centre to North Liberty; Quince, Centre to Westminster.

Omitted from this census are the thirty-six acres of the central district which were completely burned out by the conflagration of 1846 and therefore contain no structures over ninety years of age. It then, as now, included all of the business section. Many of the stores, as on Centre Street, were rebuilt quickly in an intended temporary manner, but the decline of the whaling industry and its attendant prosperity coinciding with this time, much of the temporary remained permanent. Fortunately, the numerous new styles had not arrived in 1846 and many of the dwellings built anew in the burned area were in the old taste, attractive and dignified. This area was bounded approximately by

South Wharf and Salem Street,
Both sides of Main, Union to Orange,
Both sides of Centre, Rose Lane to Broad Street,
Both sides of Broad, Centre to No. Water (excluding Ocean House),
Both sides of North Water, Broad to Ash and Sea,
Eastward from all the above to the harbor.

Our drawing, [numbered 17](#), shows the outline of this conflagration district.

CENSUS

The purpose is to analyze each house in respect to a considerable number of predominant features so as to arrive at totals which will indicate the prevailing characteristics of the old houses. These are exterior features on the front of the house or conspicuously visible from the street.

In these old districts we have tabulated 319 old dwellings, interspersed with 46 of modern or mixed design. As this includes about two-thirds of the old houses, it is representative of the whole as the rest are known to be of the same types.

Here is the list of features and the number of times each was recorded:

Walls—wood 311; brick 8.

Exterior Surface of Front Wall—shingles 179; clapboards 132; brick 8.

Exposed Foundations—brick 246; stone 65; modern replacements 8.

Height of Foundation above Ground, viz., height of first floor above ground—

High (generally with 3 or 4 panes of glass vertically in basement windows) 140.

Low (generally 1 or 2 steps to first floor; without basement windows) 97.

Intermediate (between high and low) 82.

Number of Stories—two 271; one and one-half 30; one 16; three 2.

Roof Type—gable 287; lean-to 19; hip 8; gambrel 5.

Windows—total panes of glass in the two sashes—twelve 216; twenty-four 49; eighteen 4.

Modern viz., two or four 50.

Dormers in front roof—the narrow gable roof, old type 29; wide or with shed roof 23.

Roof Walks—35 Cupolas—14 Front Roof Balustrades—11.

Door Location—toward one side of the front 227; at center of front 92.

Chimney Location—central 132; to one side of center 109; near side of building 78.

Main chimneys were always of brick, generally with six or less flues, now plastered or painted above roof and located at or near the ridge at interior of building.

Modern Detractions—noted occasionally in the 319 old houses:

Modern windows of four or two sheets of glass—50

Modern piazza or porch, generally with flat roof—51

Modern front door—odd panels, golden oak, plate glass, etc.—46

Modern bay window—35

Slim chimneys—23

Hood over front door with fancy gingerbread detail—13

Large lattice arbor obscuring front door—8

Conspicuous “sun parlors”—12

Other features. It was gratifying to observe that the following did not appear at all on the old houses or with sufficient frequency to note:

Fancy shingles—as in belts on walls and roofs or scalloped or diamond-shaped

Outside chimneys—including those of cobblestone

Gingerbread trim—except on hoods over front doors

Cement blocks—particularly those professing to simulate artificial stone

Conspicuous cement steps and walks to front door

Modern brick—such as the yellow and tapestry varieties

Conspicuous bright paint colors—particularly on blinds and doors

THE TYPICAL HOUSE

The conclusions from this analysis are inescapable, although they may never have occurred to us, viz.:

The vast majority of old Nantucket houses are of one type. Therefore it is this type that must largely make the picture of the town. This is it:

Wood walls, covered with shingles or clapboards, with the shingles weathered gray or painted. The colors of shingles (when painted) and of clapboards and trim are white, cream, gray, yellow or brown. White predominates. The exterior window and front door blinds (shutters) are painted dark green.

Basement is high with walls of brick, painted or plastered and with windows of considerable size in these walls. This high basement is a distinctly Nantucket characteristic.

Or to a somewhat less extent, the basement is low to the ground or somewhat so without any or sizeable cellar windows.

The house is two stories in height with attic.

Roof is gable type without dormers. The pitch of the gable roof is generally 9", to 12" horizontal measurement but not less than 8" pitch.

The chimney is brick, plastered or painted gray, massive, usually containing six flues, located near the ridge and at the center or to one side of the center.

The front door is at one side of the center of the front or, less frequently, at the center.

Windows are of two sashes (with 12 to 24 lights to a window), viz., from 6 to 12 lights to a sash. 12 to a window predominates on the front.

Such is our typical house.

This does not mean that the recognized old style variations from this predominant type are out of order. Far from it. Most excellent are low ledgestone foundations with or without plaster covering. One story, one and a half story and three story structures. Lean-to, gambrel and hip roofs. Interior end chimneys and small gable roofed front dormers.

THE DRAWINGS

Referring to that marked [Nos. 1 to 9](#), it will be observed that No. 1 shows the front and side of a lean-to house of the 1st period. The settlers built lean-to houses. So did the next generations. Houses of one story, of one and one-half story and of two story height in front.

All the other houses on the page are of the 2nd period; that is to say, the Colonial and early Federal times. It is obvious they are a natural development from the lean-to house.

All have gable roofs except No. 8 with gambrel roof, and No. 9 with hip roof.

Drawing [No. 10](#) shows a low basement house, with correct front door panels, lean-to projection and two-story ell.

[No. 11](#) is the more frequently found variety of the old houses, having the high basement peculiar to Nantucket, an off-side front door and center-central massive chimney. Note the wooden down spout conductors and four pane high, basement windows.

[No. 13](#). Here we see the correct small, gable roof, dormer windows and the walk at the roof ridge, access to which was gained through a trap door (skylight).

[Nos. 14](#) and [15](#). These illustrate the plank frames of windows. Observe the projection of the planks from the face of wall. These are an essential to a Nantucket house of old type.



Nos. 1 TO 9

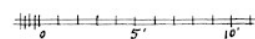
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SKETCH



FRONT ELEVATION No.10



No. 10



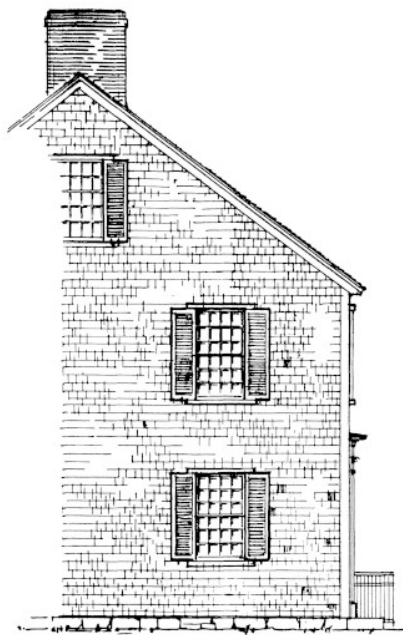
SIDE

FRONT ELEVATION

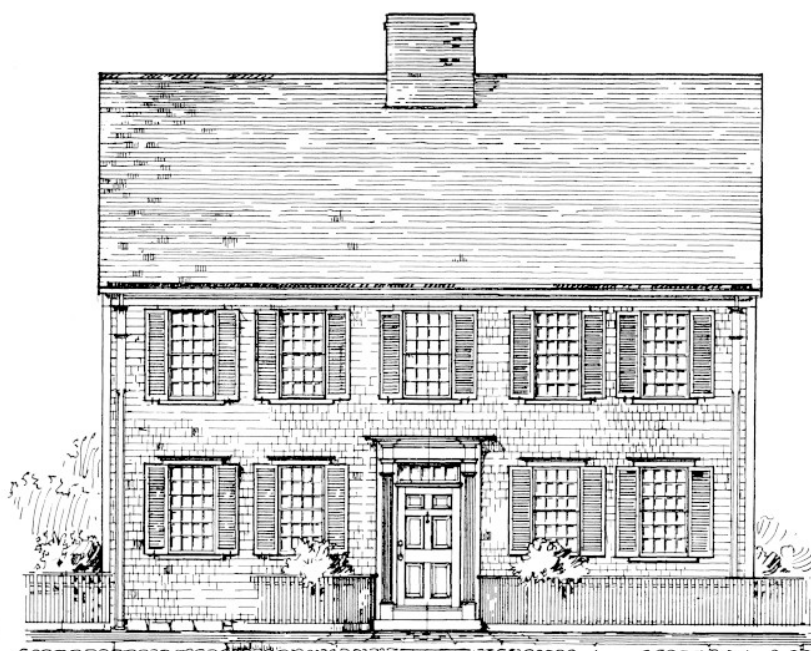


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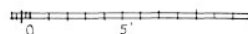
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SIDE

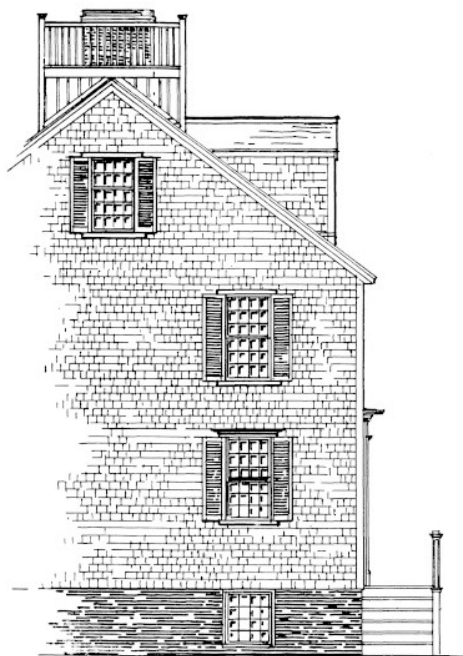


FRONT ELEVATION

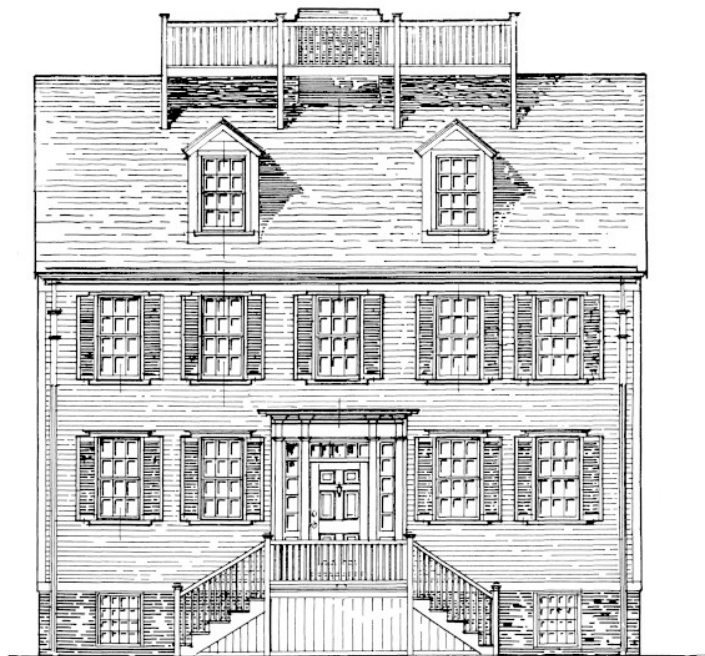


No. 12

No. 12



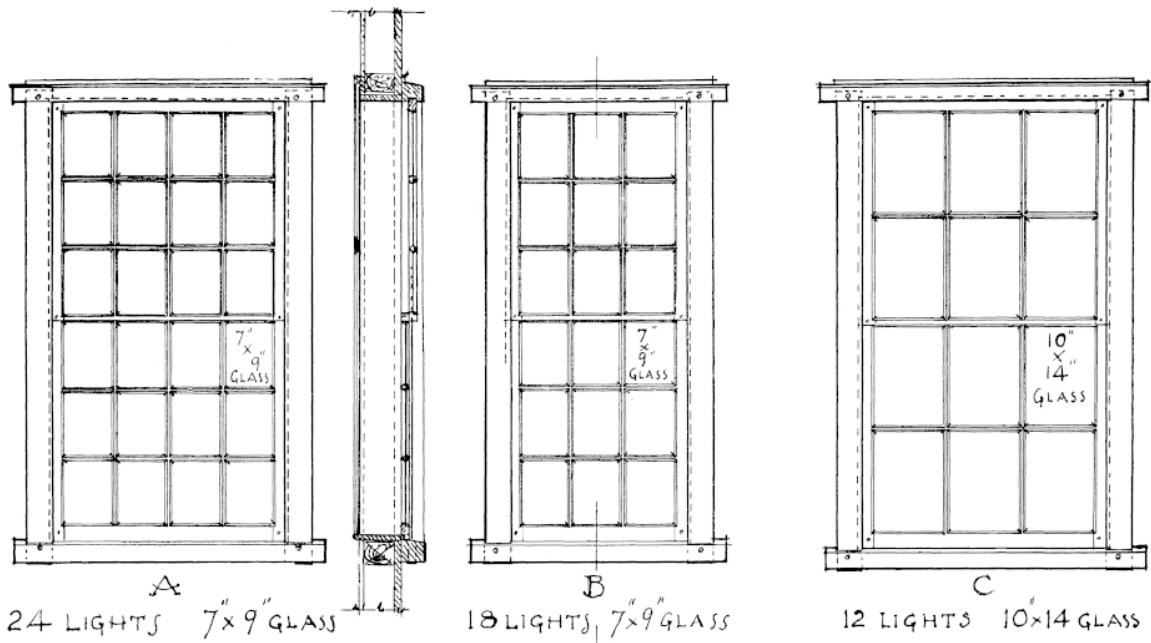
SIDE



FRONT ELEVATION

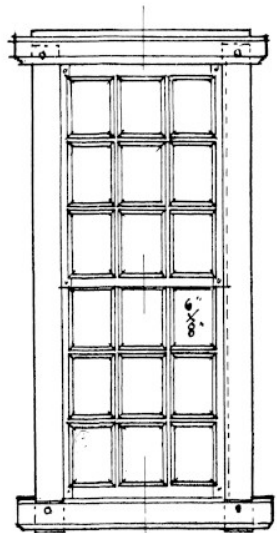
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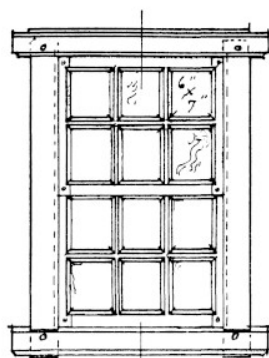


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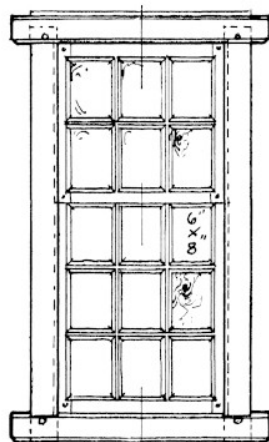
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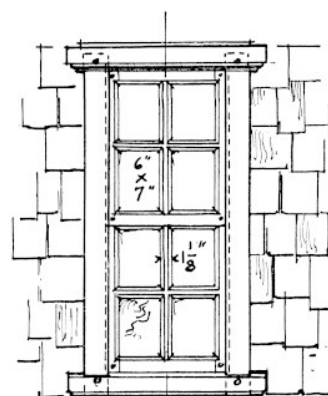
PROSPECT STR.



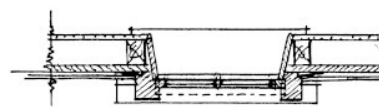
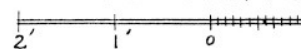
LIBERTY STREET.



PROSPECT STR.



NEAR CENTER STR.

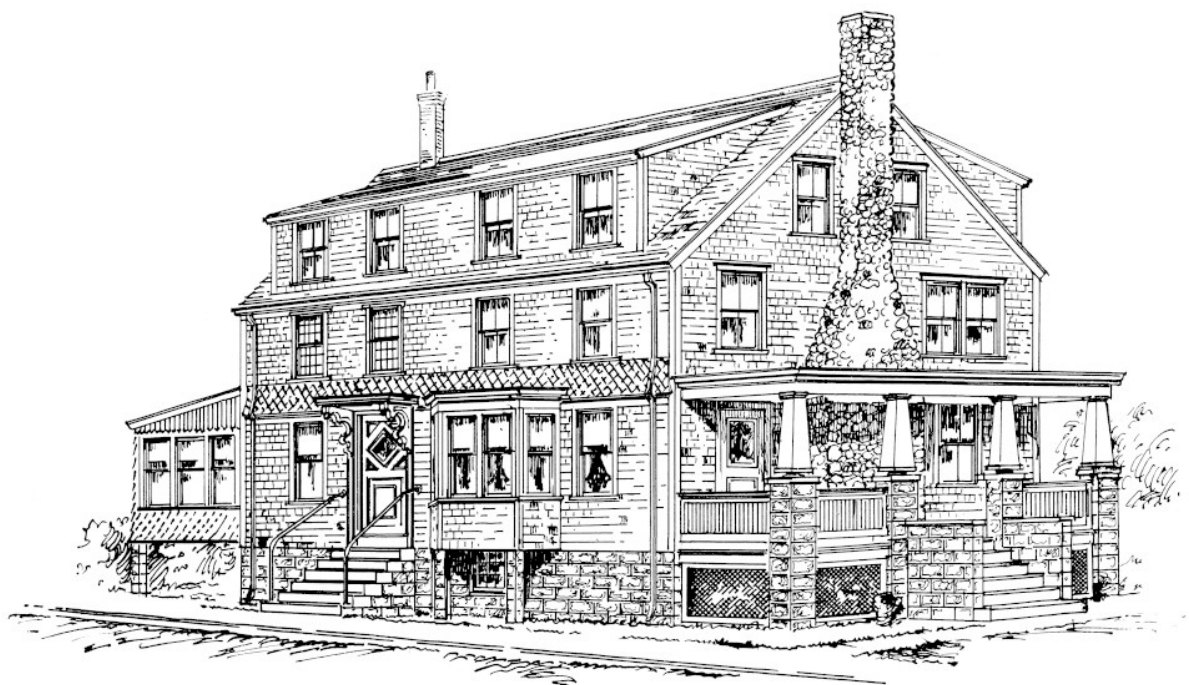


OLDER WINDOWS
CIRCA 1725-1760

No. 15

OLDER WINDOWS CIRCA 1725-1760

No. 15



· THE ALTERED HOUSE ·

Nº. 16

THE ALTERED HOUSE

No. 16

THE ALTERED HOUSE

Drawing [No. 16](#)

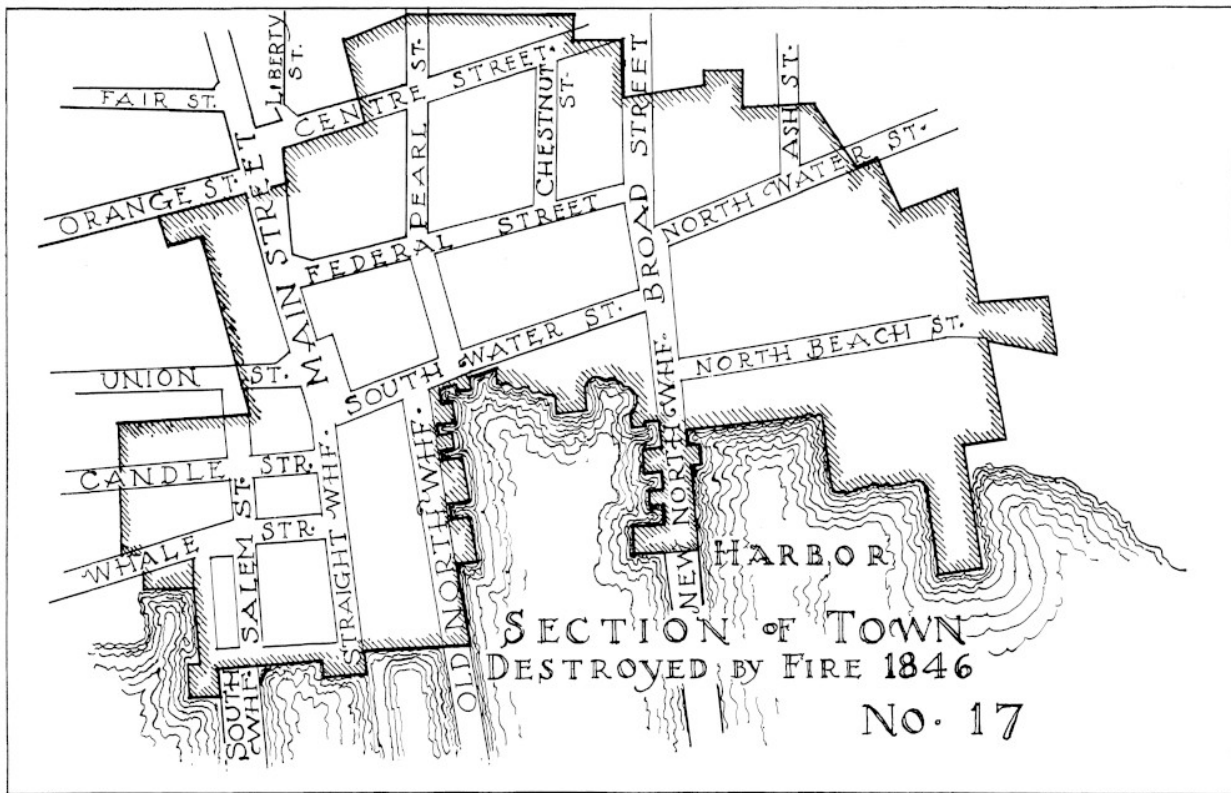
This shows what was once a perfect Nantucket house but successive owners have altered it till nothing of the original remains in view except two windows. Somebody raised the house and used artificial stone cement blocks in the foundations as well as in the battlemented steps to the piazza which has giant columns resting on miniature anti-rot pipe supports holding up a large flat roof which but partly conceals a huge exterior cobblestone chimney.

Cement steps and galvanized iron pipe hand rails lead up to the golden oak front door containing a large beveled plate glass, all surmounted by a hood held up by supporting brackets of jig-saw design.

A belt of fancy scalloped and diamond-shaped shingles extends across the front wall and large sheets of glass replace the small window panes. There is a large bay window.

At the far side a “sun parlor” transforms that end of the structure and a wide shed roof dormer completely changes the main roof.

We do not intend to comment adversely on these changes in respect to their individual merits, our purpose being to point out that one cannot make them and retain an old house.



SECTION OF TOWN DESTROYED BY FIRE 1846

No. 17

ALTERATIONS

We have a precious inheritance in this large group of old houses. Every effort should be made to keep from harming them when making changes, and to keep from building dissimilar types of new houses in the old built-up sections. There is ample room outside of the old districts or elsewhere on the Island for those who determine to build a place of modern appearance. Yet one can ride a hobby too hard. The complete purist is often impracticable. One living in an old house wants to be comfortable and to have adequate space. There is hardly an old house in town which has not on its visible exterior—at least somewhere on its four sides—the marks of modernizing as made by succeeding generations. Fortunately the fronts as a rule have been but little marred.

Nantucket can be kept “95% perfect” only by not adding to the visible detractions on its old houses, and by not building new types amidst the old. Thus this priceless inheritance will be preserved—and incidentally the values increased—as such houses become less and less procurable here and elsewhere. We even venture to hope some of the present detractions will be removed as time goes on.

So far as more room and modern comforts are concerned, an architect or builder knowing his old Nantucket can usually plan to provide them in “doing over” an old house and still not harm its exterior. But all hope is lost if the roof lines are spoiled by large shed-roof dormers or a dormer room, and only less disfiguring are large “sun parlors,” piazzas, exterior chimneys, or flat roofed ells or projections, built where visible from the front.

To bring home what we mean—imagine that a conflagration sweeps this town and destroys it. The land would remain, the climate, sea bathing, sailing, outdoor and indoor sports, and the moors. Inevitably, however, a part, probably a small part, would be built up anew and there could be no possible control of the styles. We would then have a small village like any

other modern one along the Atlantic seaboard, entirely devoid of quaintness, charm or interest. Nantucket would then be in its second decline, perhaps just as severe as after the end of the whaling.

EARLY INFLUENCES

It is interesting to contemplate what influenced our prevailing architecture. First, as in many other affairs, it was the almighty dollar. In the 18th century, and much of the first quarter of the 19th, there was little spare cash available on this Island. That which was accumulated, and more, was needed for outfitting ships. Hence the houses were built inexpensively and of moderate size.

Second, the Quakers put their indelible stamp on Nantucket houses, particularly those built from 1750 to 1825. Worth tells us the Society of Friends reached its highest tide of membership and influence on the Island a few years prior to the opening of the 19th century. At this time the population of Nantucket was about 5,600 and nearly one-half attended Friends Meeting. The most potent cause of the decline of Quakerism was the enforcement of their discipline. They required utmost simplicity and utmost plainness in detail of their houses. He recites an event which took place as late as 1790, when Job Macy was building his house on Mill Street. When his father discovered that the plan was to erect a house of two stories, both front and rear, without a lean-to and a long north sloping roof, he expostulated with Job for the innovation and vowed that if the house was built in the new style as proposed he would never enter it, and tradition is that he never did. An incident of the same nature and of about the same time is reported by Hussey. When a certain house near Stone Alley was being erected from frames made on the mainland, it was found to be upright all around, the back two stories high like the front and so without the regulation long back roof. To some of the Islanders this caused uneasiness, as being likely to introduce change and extravagance. A citizens' meeting was convened and the owner requested to cut down the back posts. Good man as he was, he complied.

Third, relative affluence, when it came, was derived from or had its origin in the sea. It was possessed by the ship captains and ship owners.

They were influenced by the balance and carpentry of ships. This extended to their dwellings. During the latter part of the prosperity period, approximately from 1825 to 1860, some of these men had become merchants and capitalists. They enjoyed themselves on shore and built the few mansions with which we are familiar.

DETAILS OF OLD HOUSES

Back Side or Rear of Houses. Fortunately most of these are not seen from the street, due to the proximity of adjacent houses. This is the first place for extensions and additions, such as a first floor kitchen with its small chimney, more sleeping rooms, and if one must or needs, and the compass points allow, a "sun parlor," a columned piazza, French doors, wide dormers, even (but we hope not) the dormer room in the rear roof, and pergolas. If understanding care is exercised, part of this can be well done.

Roof Coverings. Regret it as one may, but quite properly under the fire ordinances, wood shingle roofs are fast disappearing, with the shadow lines cast by the thick shingle butts. It is, however, feasible to use individual non-inflammable shingles of dark gray or black which are inconspicuous, and if one has the price and inclination and strength of rafters, an asbestos reproduction of old shingles, absolutely faithful to type and attractive, is available and should be employed, as see the house at 86 Centre Street.

White Trim. We venture to make note of the largely prevailing present custom of painting white the exterior trim of houses, including particularly the window casings, referring only to the houses where the exterior walls are not painted white but are of shingles, weathered gray. This has the effect of outlining the windows and the edges of the facades with extreme emphasis. Attention is directed to those weathered gray shingled houses where, instead, the trim has been painted in harmony and not in sharp contrast to the gray. For this purpose some shades of gray paint have been used, and in some of the older houses a dull brown. The owner of such a gray shingled house, planning to re-paint the exterior, should look at the examples referred to and consider whether they would please his taste. In the early days of paint a red color was used, doubtless appearing as a dull reddish brown. In altering very old houses it has been found on the exterior of the beveled boards which were the outside of the wall when no shingles or clapboards were used.

Blinds. The louvered (slanted slat) blinds on exterior walls at windows and front doors began to come into use about 1840. They certainly do dress up a house but otherwise have little or no use at Nantucket. A really old house is in the best of taste without them and with a saving of expense. Always (on an old house) they should be painted a dark green. The earliest were quite heavy, without moveable louvers. Most now in existence are lighter weight and usually with tilting slats, an unnecessary provision. Solid paneled shutters, general in many parts of the country, as at Philadelphia, were not used at Nantucket.

Conductors. Fortunately, modern sheet metal down spouts from gutters to take the water down to or under ground are inconspicuous. They have been freely used to replace the older spouts which have decayed. It is, however, feasible, desirable and quite inexpensive to replace with wooden down spouts of either circular or square section like the originals.

Front Doorway. This opening into the house was closed by a door of six raised panels with flush mouldings, the topmost pair of panels small, and very seldom taken out and replaced with glass. A characteristic of these doors was that the middle rail was wide, almost 10", with the bottom rail much narrower. Many of the old doorways had no glass about them, but as time advanced glass was used across the top of the doorway, spoken of as a top light or transom, and glass was employed vertically on either side of the door, known as sidelights. Very infrequently at Nantucket the muntins of the top light radiate from the center to either a circular or oval top, known as a fanlight.

Architectural ornamentation on the exterior wall surrounding the doorway, known as the frontispiece, was not employed in the older houses, many of which had plain plank frames with a header, but after the Revolution the frontispiece came more and more into use, but even then was not highly ornate. Many frontispieces now seen on the old houses were added in the period from 1800 to 1850 and followed the designs in English architectural books. Recessed doorways appeared in the classic period, accompanied by fewer panels and heavier mouldings. Plain double-boarded outside doors were undoubtedly used in the oldest houses. Paneled doors appeared in Nantucket probably about 1730.

Entry. The modern name for this is vestibule. Reference is to the enclosed projection over the front door infrequently found on the old houses. This had a gable roof and sometimes side windows. It generally entered directly into the stairway hall or, in older times, into the kitchen. It usually occurred that entries were not constructed with the original house but added subsequently.

Windows. At Nantucket, prior to about 1720, leaded panes were used. From then on to around 1790 small panes, about 5" × 7", were used with wooden muntins, and mostly three lights wide. From about 1790 to about 1825 glass was generally about 7" × 9" with 24 lights, except that many narrow panes were used with less number of lights. Muntins grew smaller as time advanced. From about 1825 on, 12 lights were mostly used, with 8" × 10" and 10" × 14" glass, almost invariably 3 lights wide. The large panes (sheet glass) came into general use soon after the Civil War, about 1865, using one or two such panes to a sash. While our census shows in the old houses a large proportion having but 12 panes to a front window, it is a fact that in a majority of these houses part or all of the side windows and the rear windows are apt to be of 24 panes. Therefore at some period the front windows had been replaced to conform to the even then changing mode and the improved financial status of the owner, or frequently second-hand material was employed in building a new house, when old multi-paned sash was used at the rear and the sides while new 6-light sash were built for the front.

Window frames on old houses were of plank and projected from the wall. See drawings No. 14 and No. 15. It is most important to faithfully continue this practice in all alterations and new construction. The Nantucket carpenters are accustomed to make such frames.

Roof Walks. You will observe from quotations of old writings to be found later in this book that they were most frequent. They are not today, our analysis showing but 35 in a total of 319 houses. It has been stated that after the decline of whaling these walks were taken down when they got out of repair and since they no longer served a useful purpose. They were called "walks," and for the purpose of identification they are here spoken of as roof walks. How the late William F. Macy decried their being called "captains' walks" or "widows' walks!"

High Basements. The massive chimneys were frequently of large area at the lowest level. This was for a bake oven and cooking fireplace, located in the basement. These basements extended several feet above and below the ground level, with ample windows, generally four panes high, and contained the kitchen, sometimes spoken of as the winter kitchen. The basements were sheltered from the wind and cold during the winter season.

Cupolas and Roof Balustrades. These were not employed here until about 1800, mostly 1830 to 1860, and are not much in evidence.

“95% Perfect.” Manifestly this was a generalization to crystallize an impression, yet our census analysis of 365 houses in the old districts shows but 46 modern or mixed type, intermingled; say 12½%. On the old houses we find various added modern detractions, frequently several kinds on one house, but many of them not serious. So let us estimate that these old-district dwellings are still 85% perfect—an astonishingly large percentage of unharmed oldness to be found in this day and generation in over 400 closely grouped houses. We have much to be thankful for.

DATED HOUSES

Many exterior features assist in suggesting the approximate date or origin of an old house and a knowledge of what is behind the exterior would allow a more accurate conclusion. But this information is not needed for our purposes.

We would like to say, however, that fixing a precise year date for the building of a house is most difficult here in Nantucket, just as it has been found to be, for those attempting to do so, in respect to old houses at off-island locations. There is no evidence of building material being derived from trees growing on this Island except by the early settlers. Statements found in early writings speak of house frames being brought from the mainland. There is knowledge of much timber and lumber and shingles being brought, principally from Maine, but also from New Hampshire and Massachusetts. Packets made frequent voyages to Maine in the early days. Even firewood was brought from the mainland. Hence, second-hand building material was saved and used again and even again, including window-sash and doors. Houses were frequently moved in whole or in part. There are many larger and more expensive houses on the sites of smaller, older ones. Occasionally houses were removed to make room for lawns and to give more light and air to the remaining houses. In the years after the decline and demise of the whaling industry, great numbers were taken down and the material shipped away, often to distant points, or used for local firewood. As an illustration, Messrs. George C. Gardner and Allen Smith are reported to have taken down some 270 houses during a decade or more after the Civil War, many being sent to Cape Cod, at times cut into bays and shipped on deck.

Old Deeds and Wills record a certain lot of land "with house thereon." Frequently, this causes the present-day owner to willingly assume that his present "house thereon" is the same. The number of houses out of this 319, where evidence could be adduced which would stand in a court of law,

showing the year in which the existing house was built, are very few. But what of it, so long as we do not fool ourselves. The error in fixing the precise date of the building of a house is well described by Worth in Nant. Hist. Assn. V. 2, Bul. 5, which might be read to advantage by those who set much store in exact dates.

CONCLUSION

Simplicity, directness, proportion, balance and truth of expression are the fundamentals of this architectural style. In our modern, quantity production, machine age, with forms and materials largely new and constantly changing, old Nantucket town offers to many whose taste is not for the restless experimental new but for the proven old, a haven of rest, peace, comfort and constant delight.

THE PHOTOGRAPHS

Sufficient houses have been photographed to illustrate fully the text. They have been well chosen for this purpose but are no more interesting, in their oldness, than the much greater number which we regret not showing, due to a limit of size for this book.

Here you will find houses of the three periods with all the described characteristics: old and new; good and bad.

The architectural details desired are shown as viewed in November and May. Admittedly, much more charming views of a number could be obtained from different angles or distances or when the foliage is on and the shadows present.



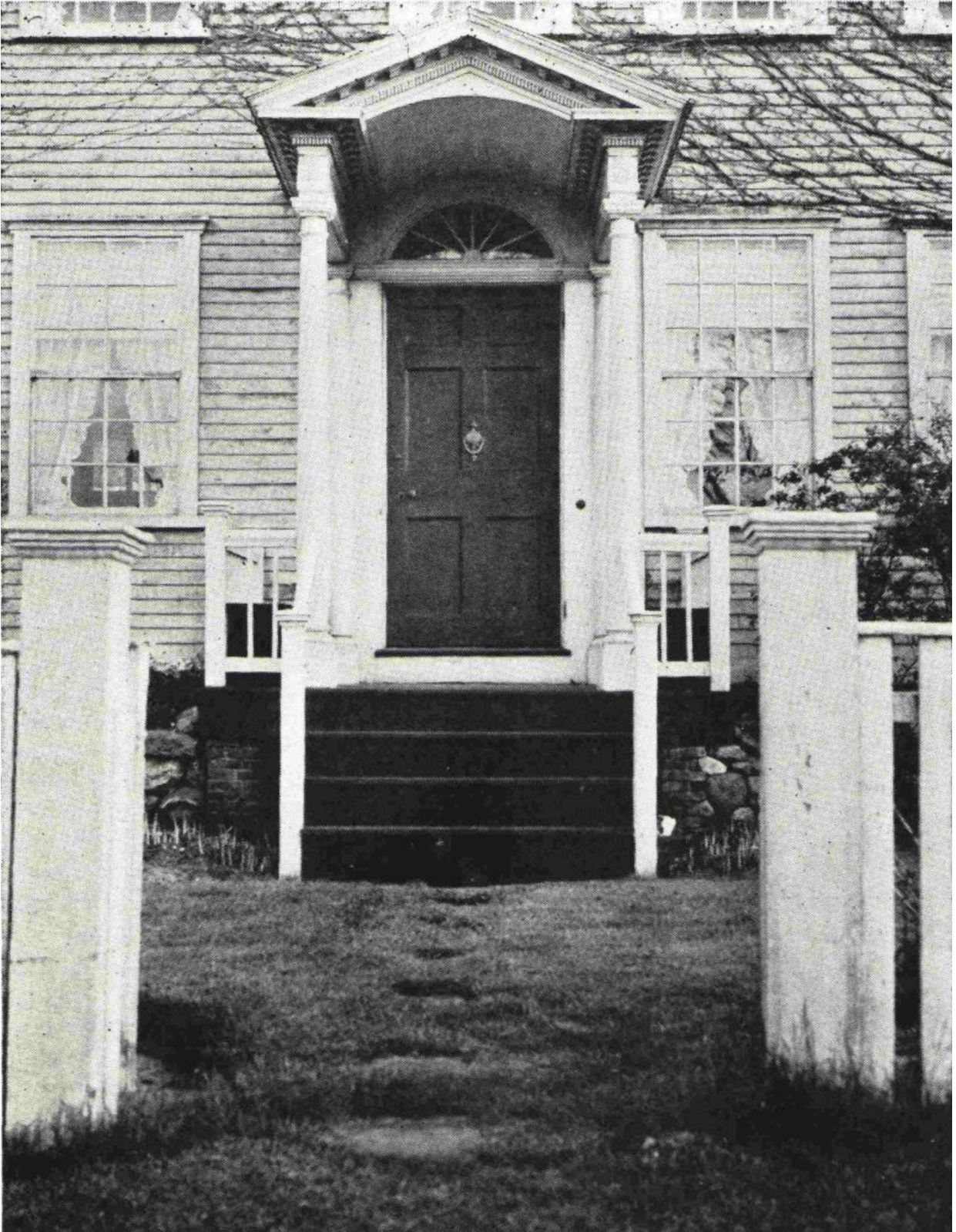
15 PEARL ST.



109 MAIN ST.



19 LIBERTY ST.



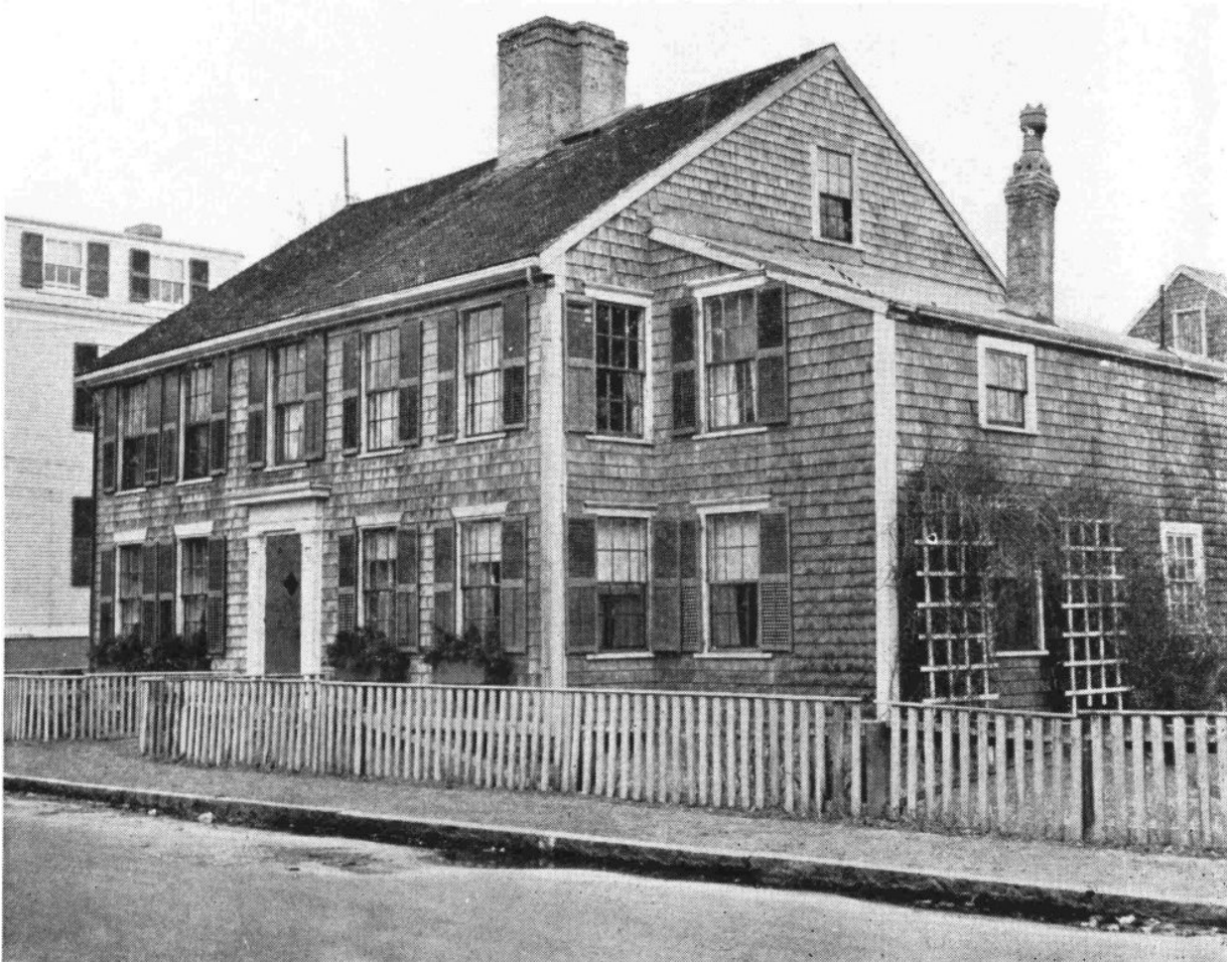
ACADEMY HILL



58 FAIR ST.



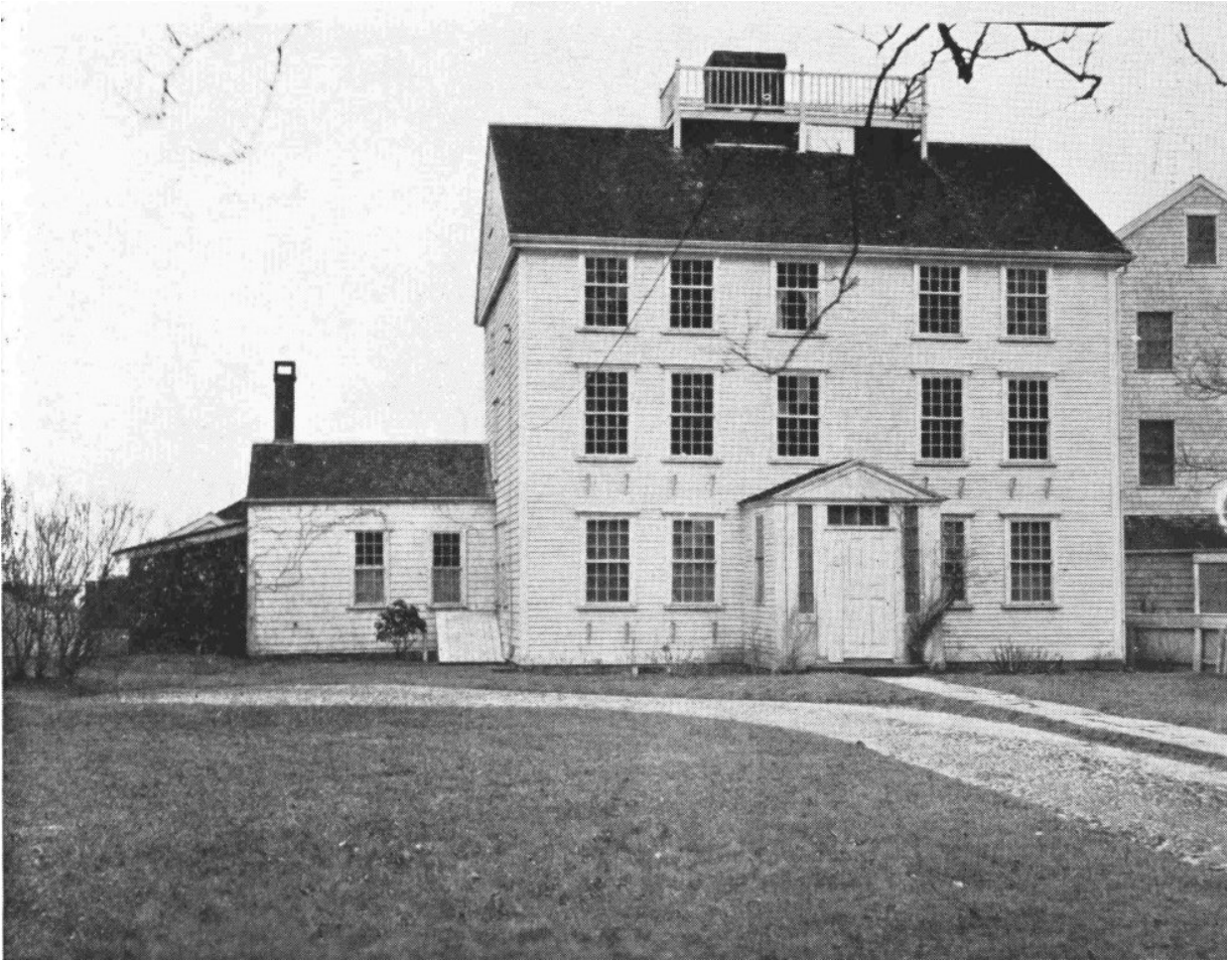
3 ACADEMY LANE



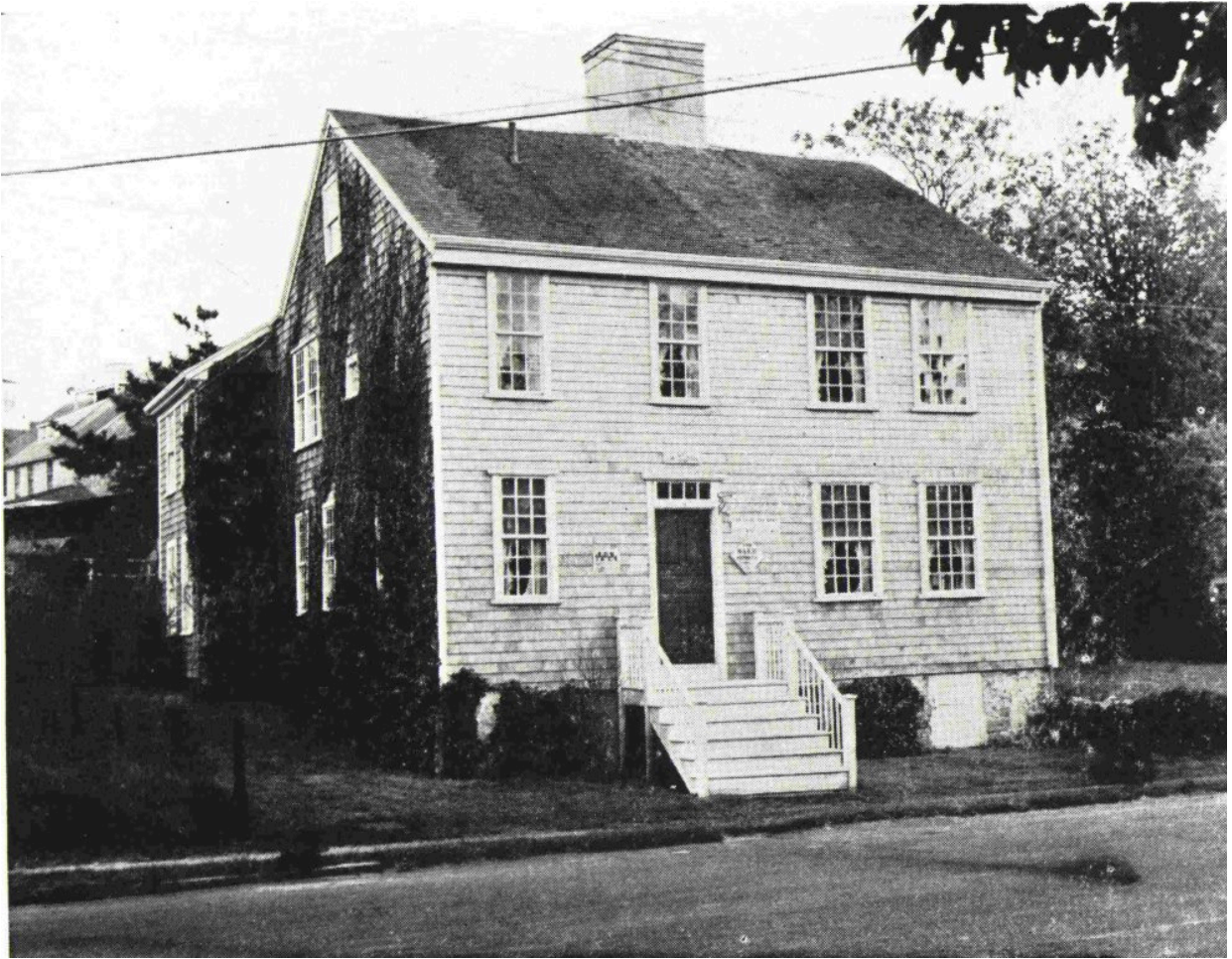
43 CENTRE ST.



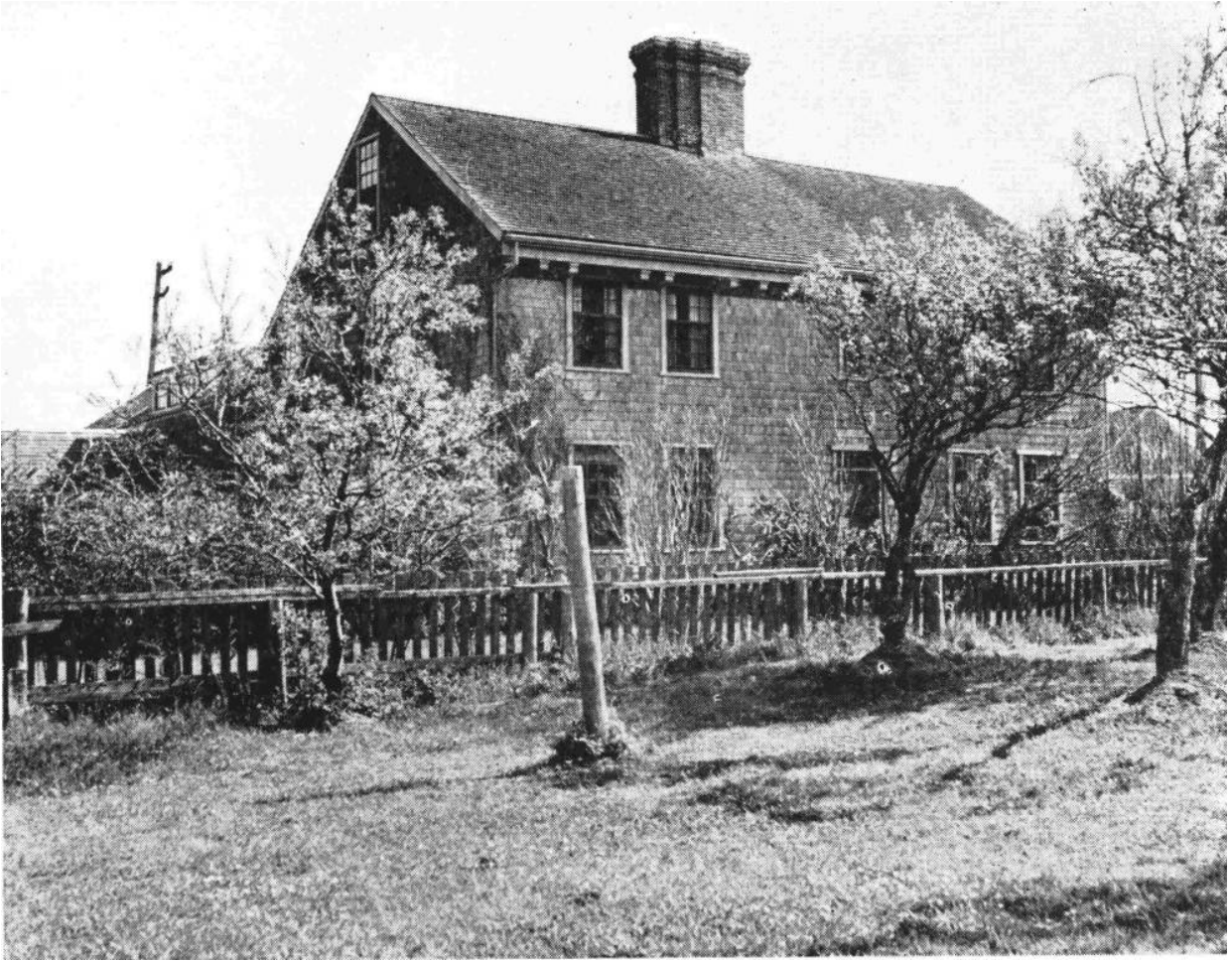
47 CENTRE ST.



51 CENTRE ST.



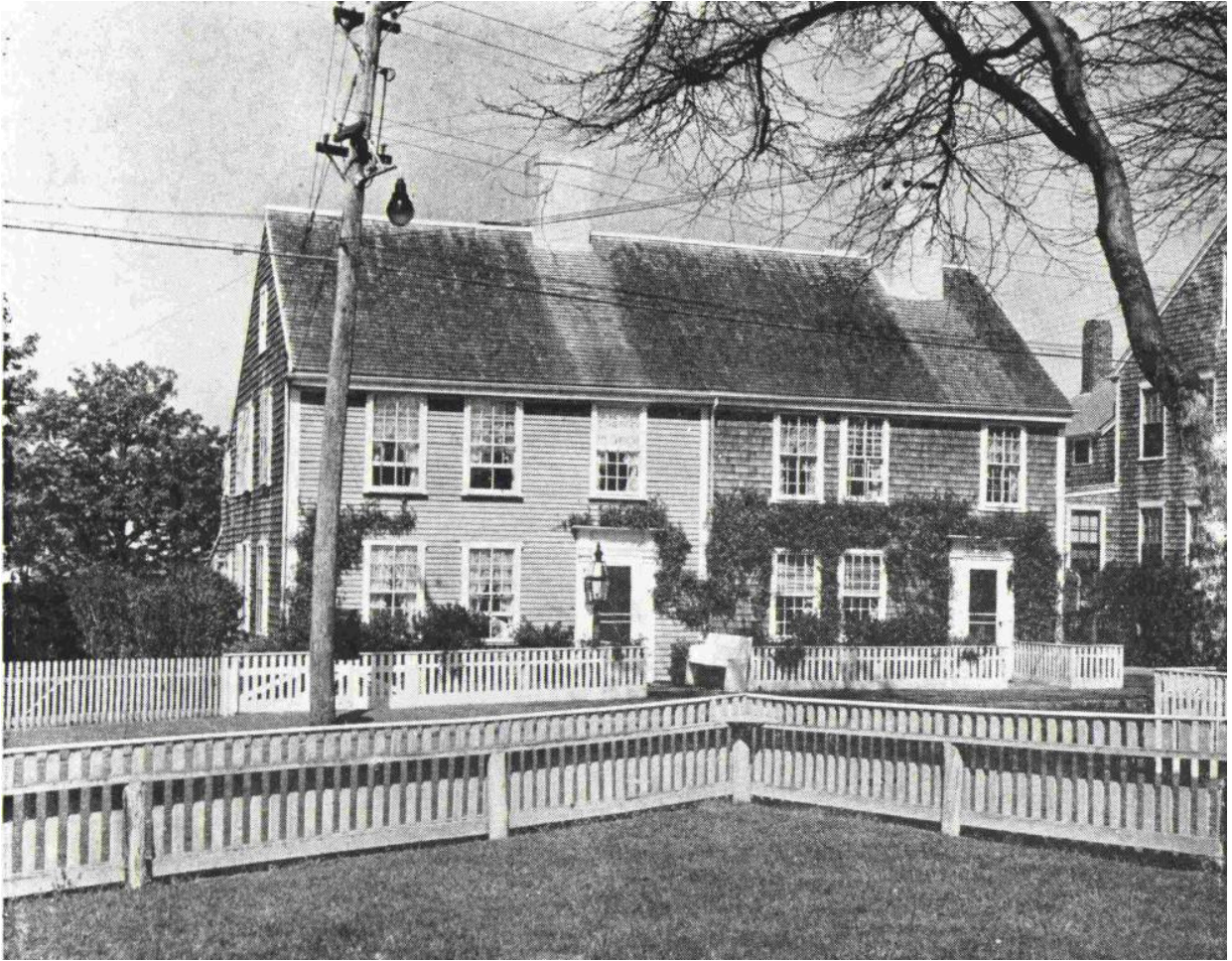
2 CHESTER ST.



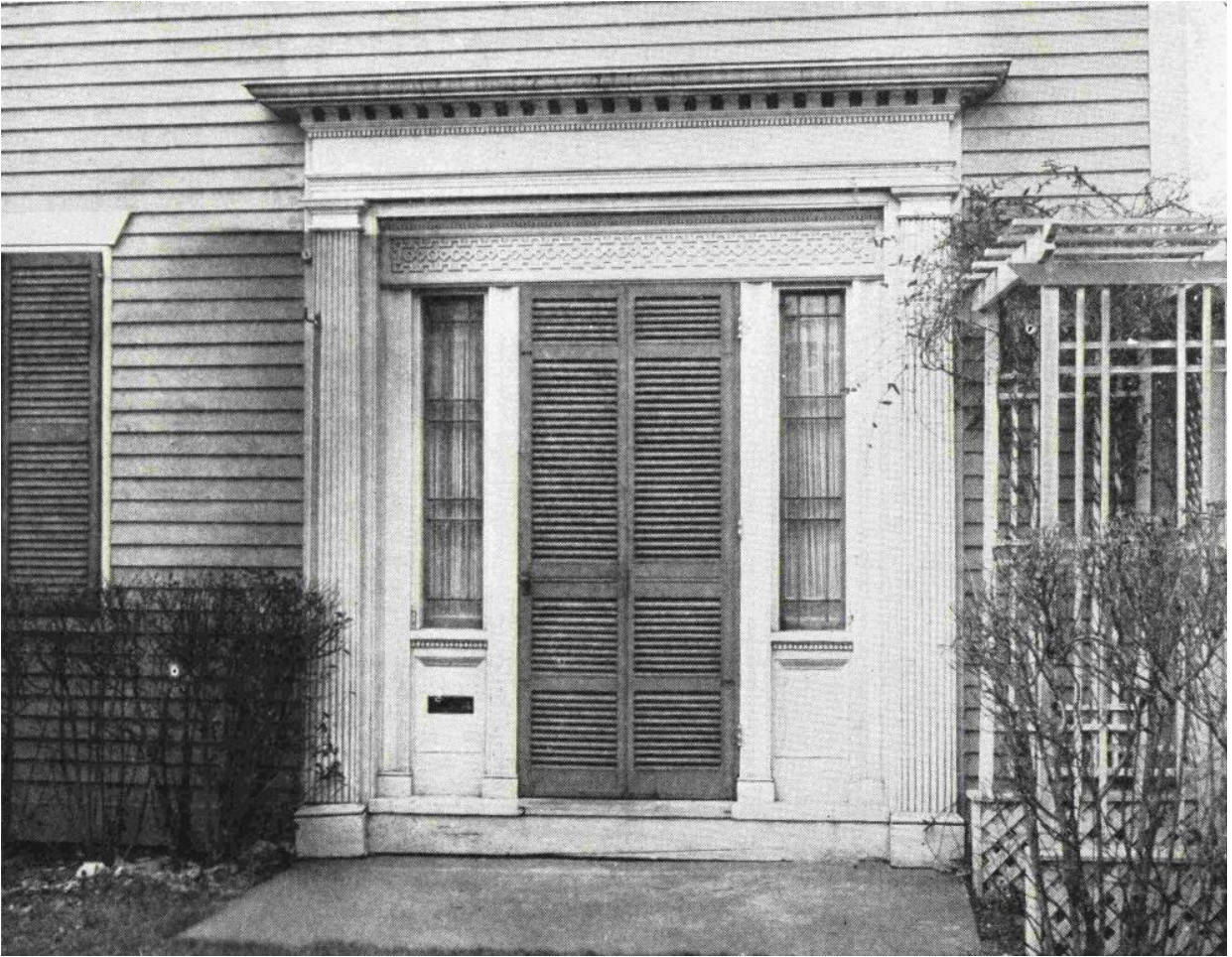
60 CLIFF ROAD



15 FAIR ST.



29 AND 31 FAIR ST.



60 FAIR ST.



10 GARDNER ST.



16 GARDNER ST.



5 GAY ST.



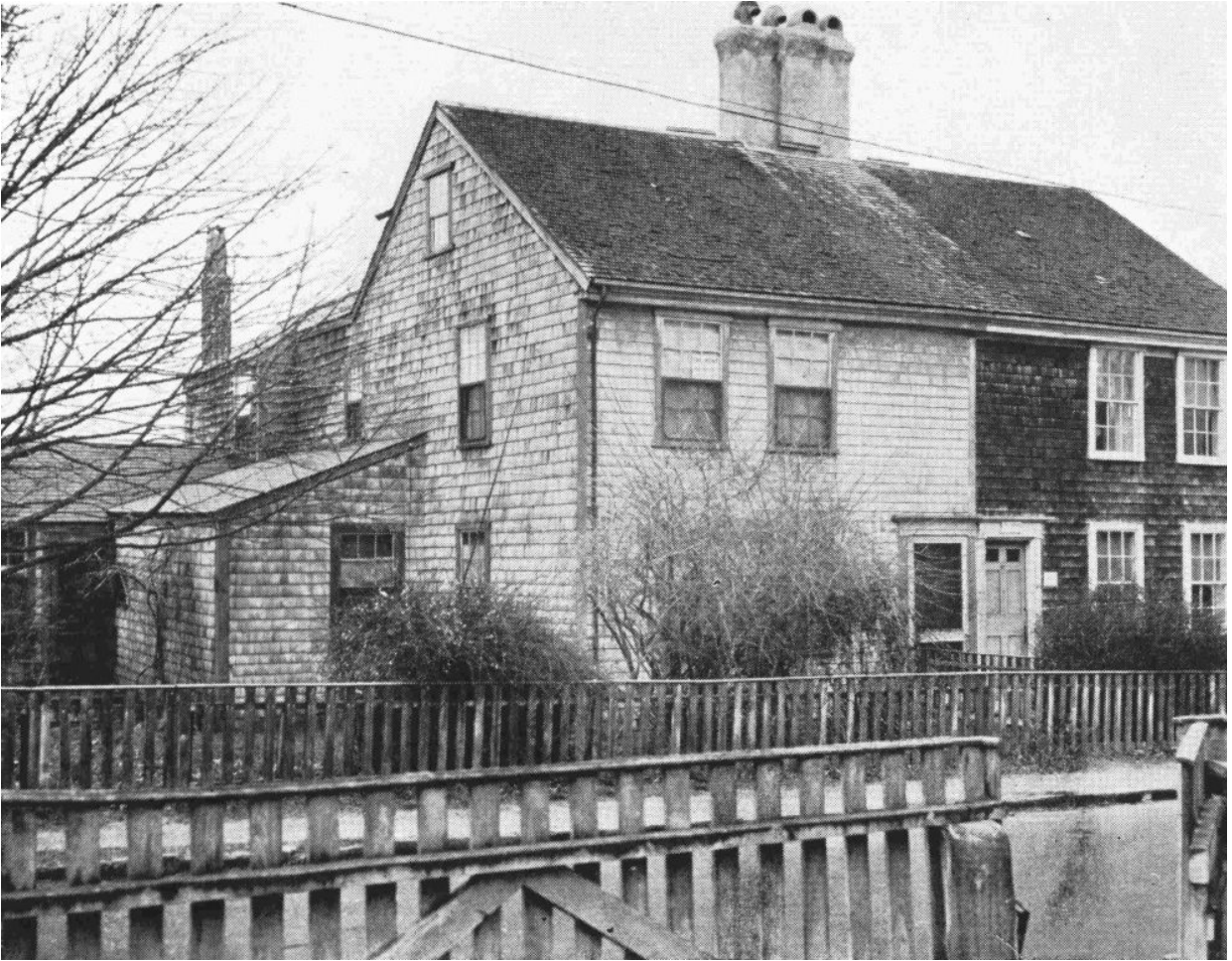
2 GORHAM'S COURT



15 LIBERTY ST.



26 LIBERTY ST.



27 AND 29 LIBERTY ST.



31 LILY ST.



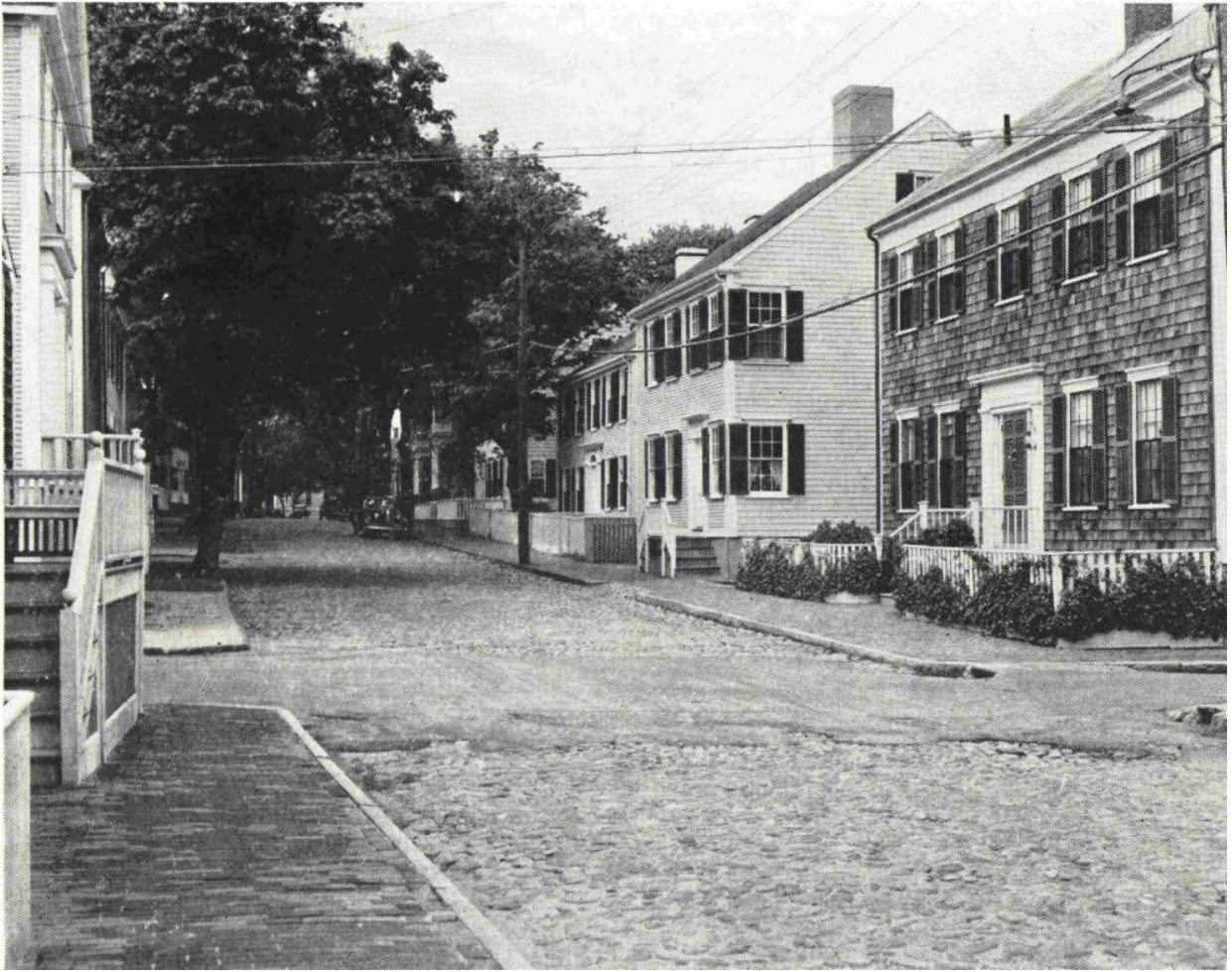
72 MAIN ST.



75 MAIN ST.



78 MAIN ST.



85 AND 87 MAIN ST.



91 MAIN ST.



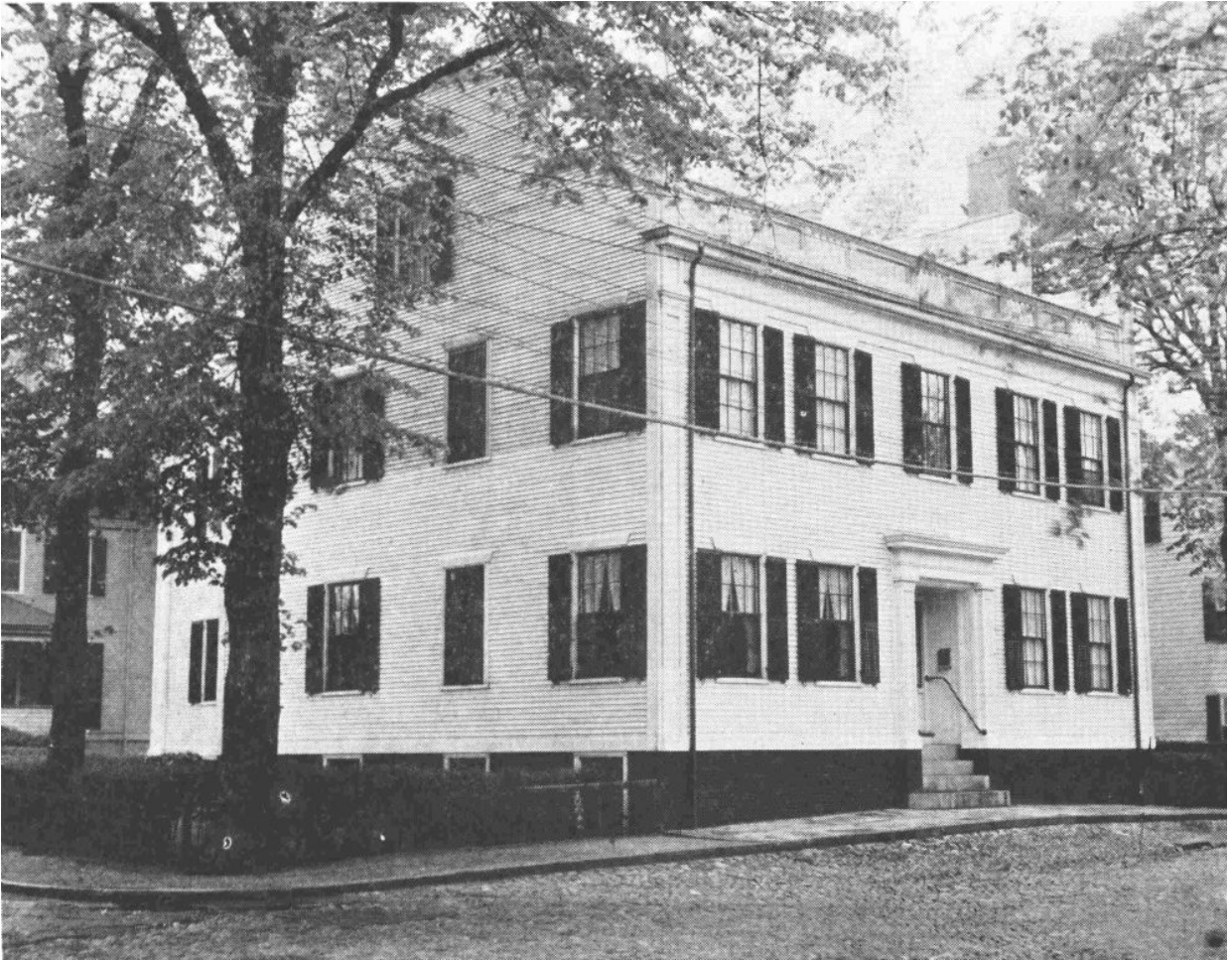
94 MAIN ST.



95 MAIN ST.



96 MAIN ST.



98 MAIN ST.



99 MAIN ST.



100 MAIN ST.



102 MAIN ST.



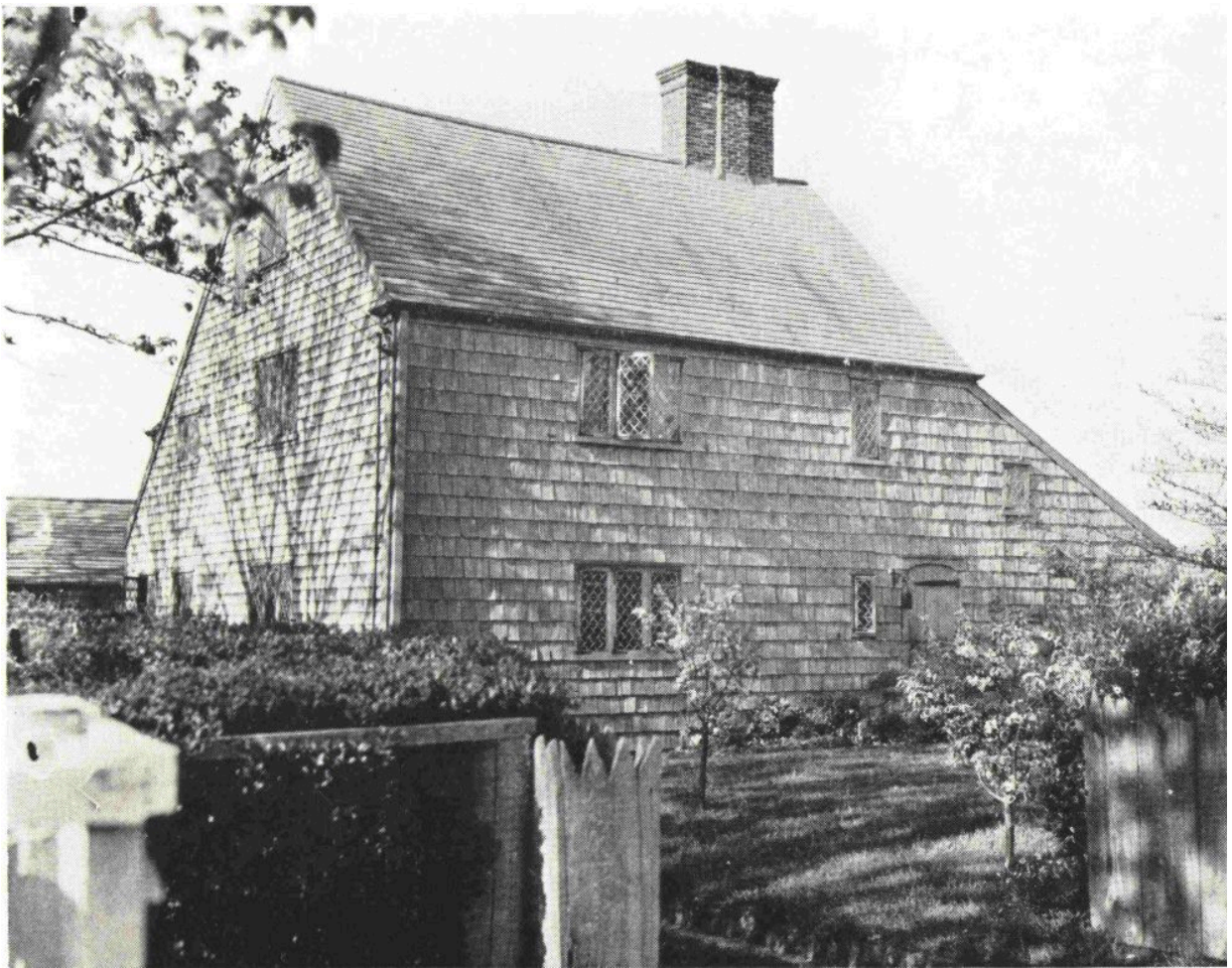
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117 MAIN ST.



121 MAIN ST.



139 MAIN ST.



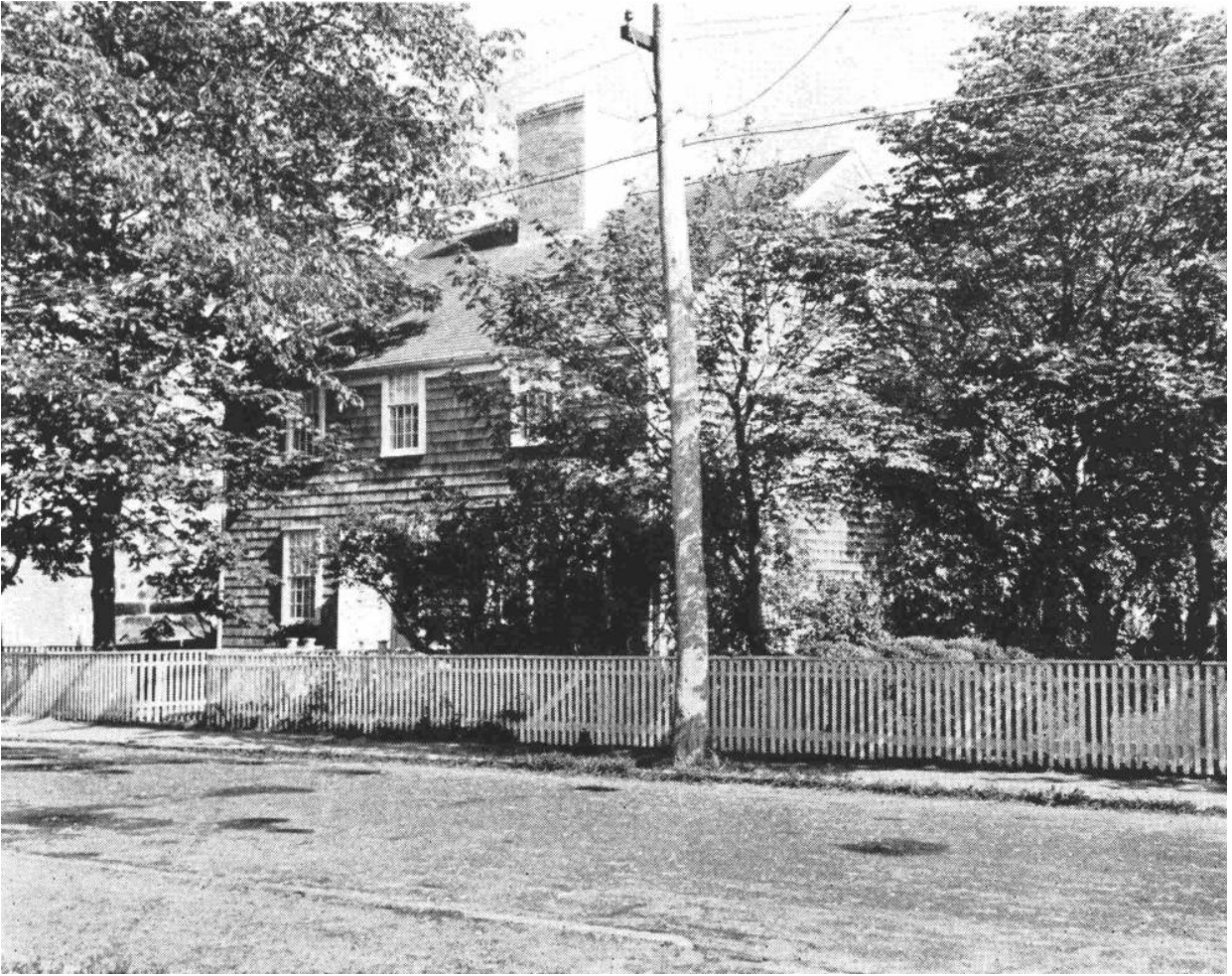
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11 MILK ST.



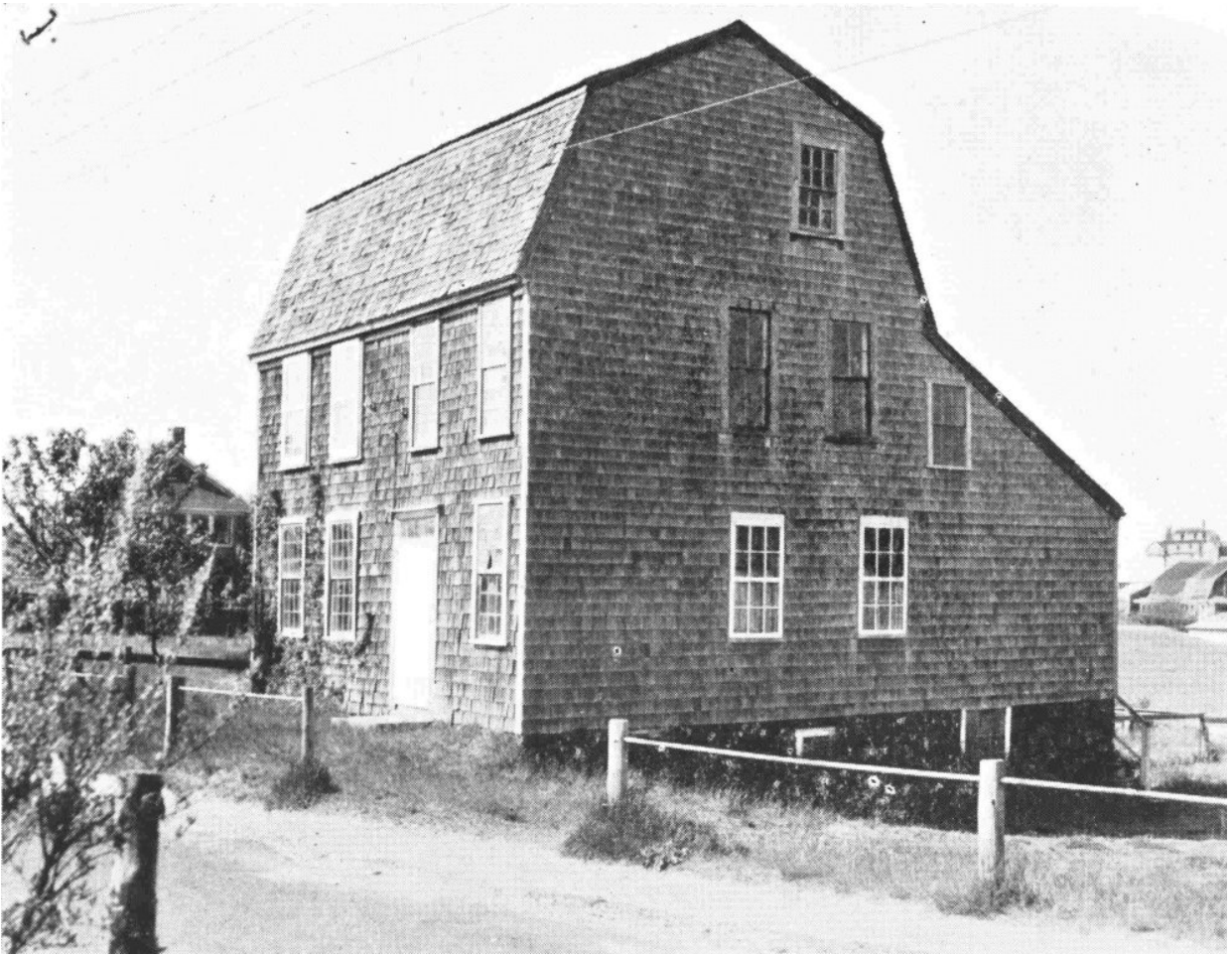
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8 MILL ST.



9 MILL ST.



17 No. LIBERTY ST.



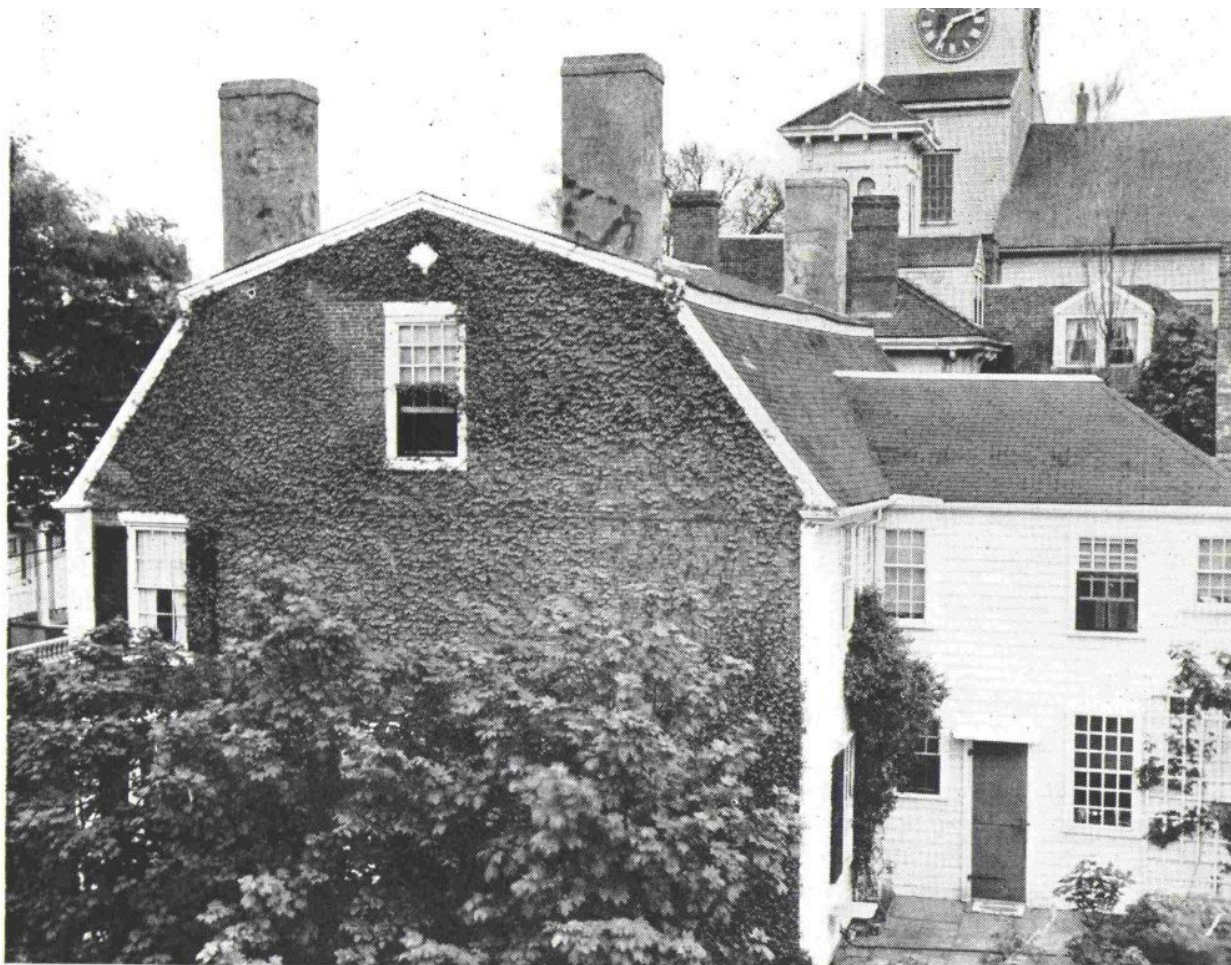
47 No. LIBERTY ST.



15 No. WATER ST.



23 No. WATER ST.



5 ORANGE ST.



“THE BLOCK,” ORANGE ST.



14 ORANGE ST.



40 ORANGE ST.



33 ORANGE ST.



53 ORANGE ST.



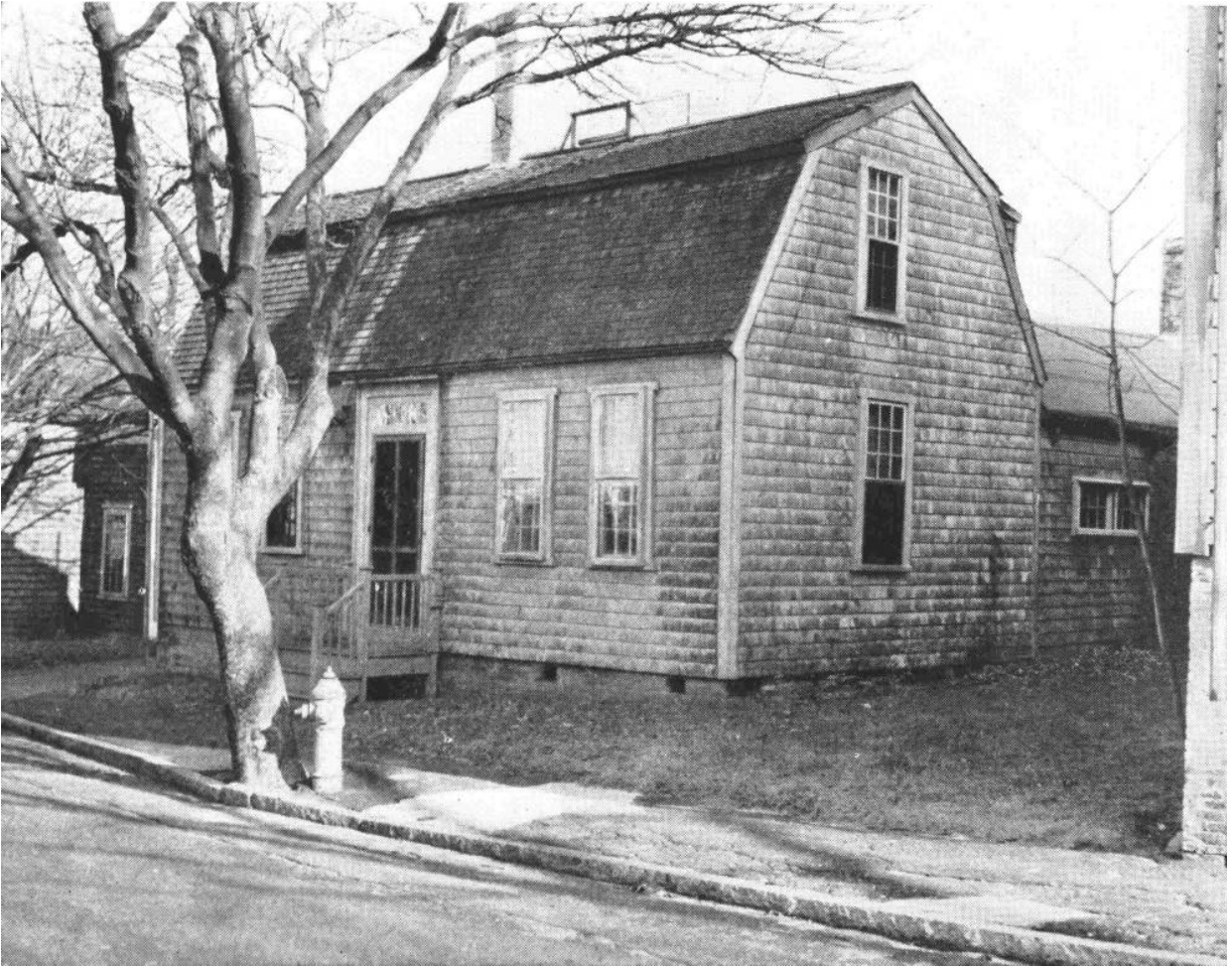
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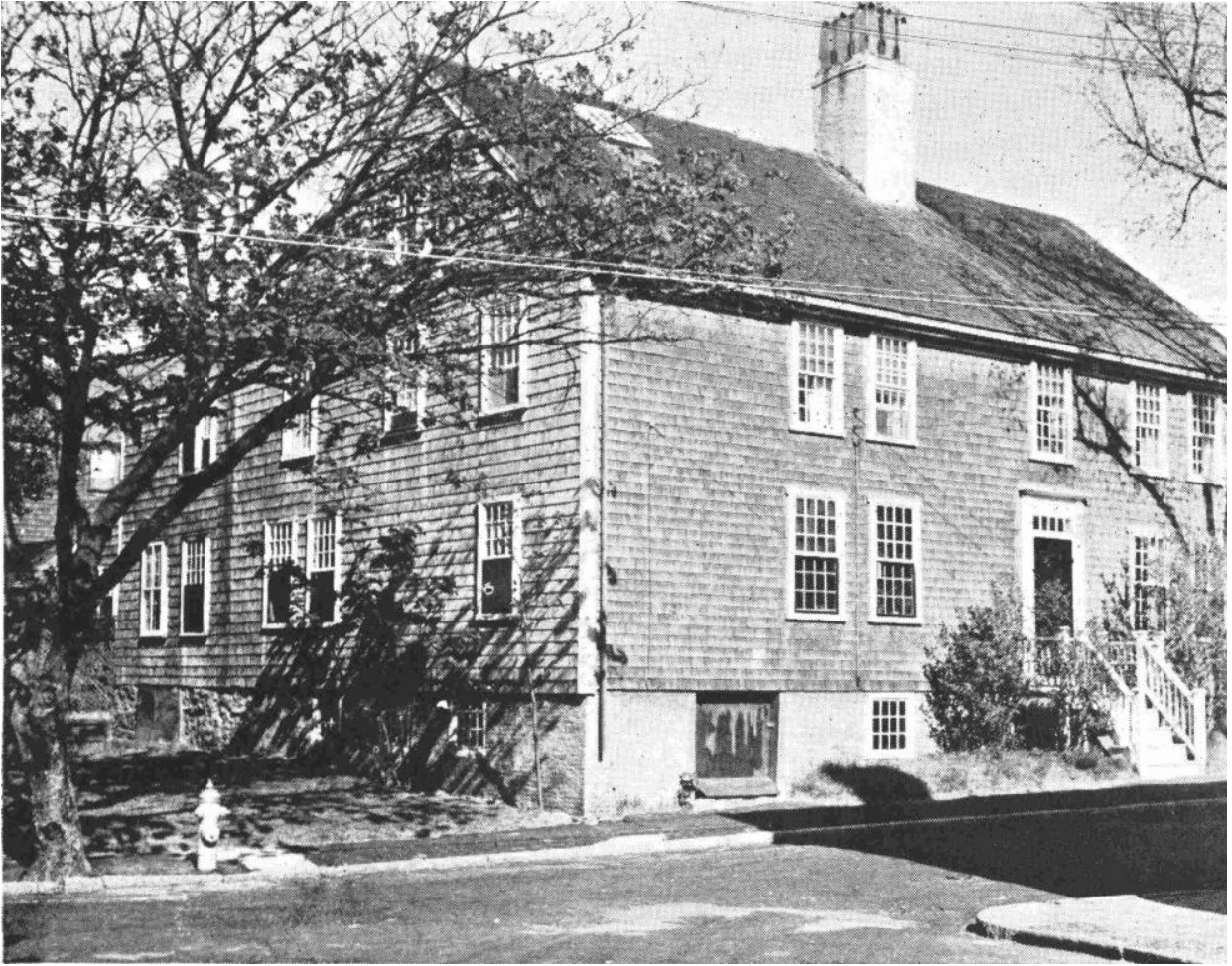
28 PEARL ST.



43 PEARL ST.



8 PINE ST.



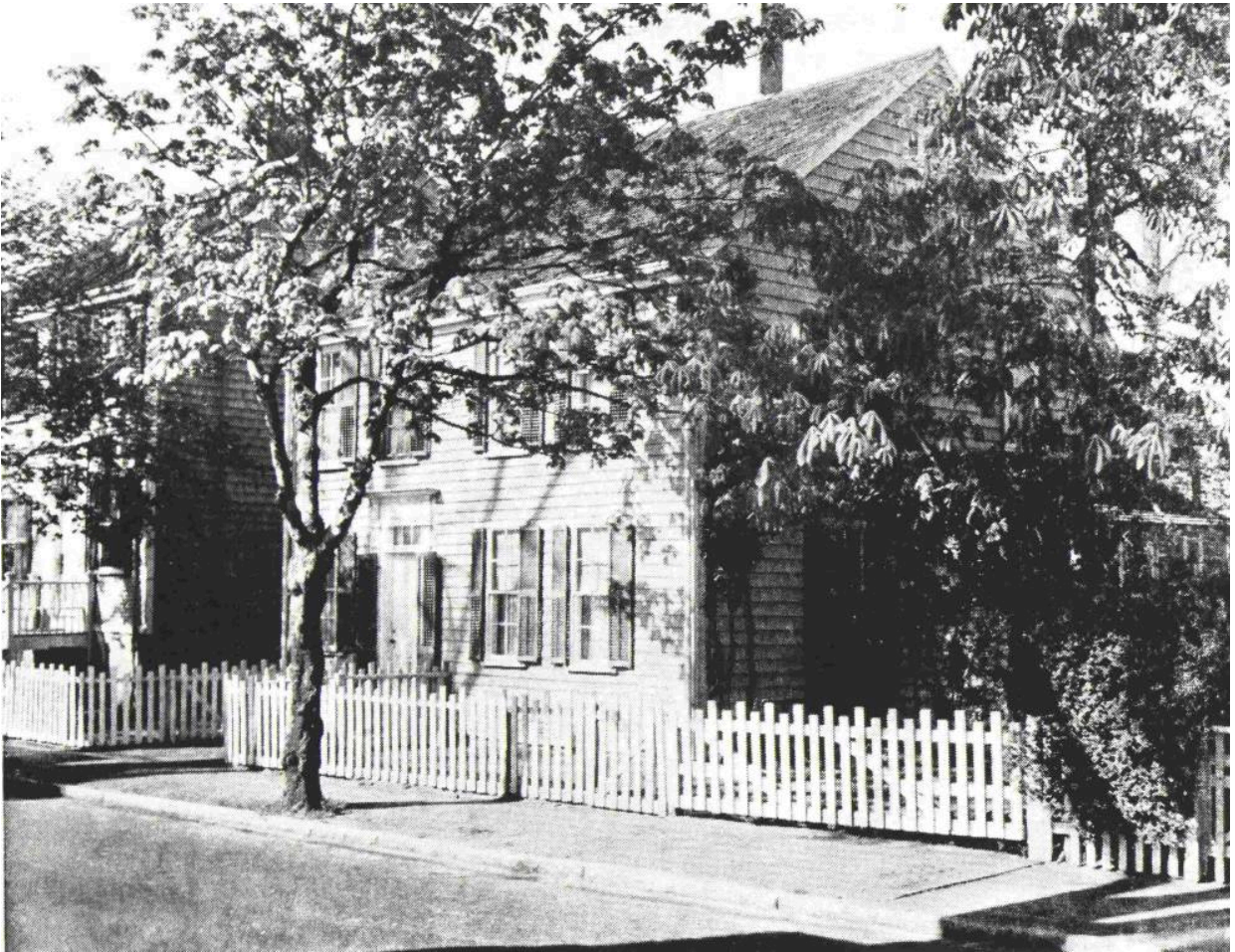
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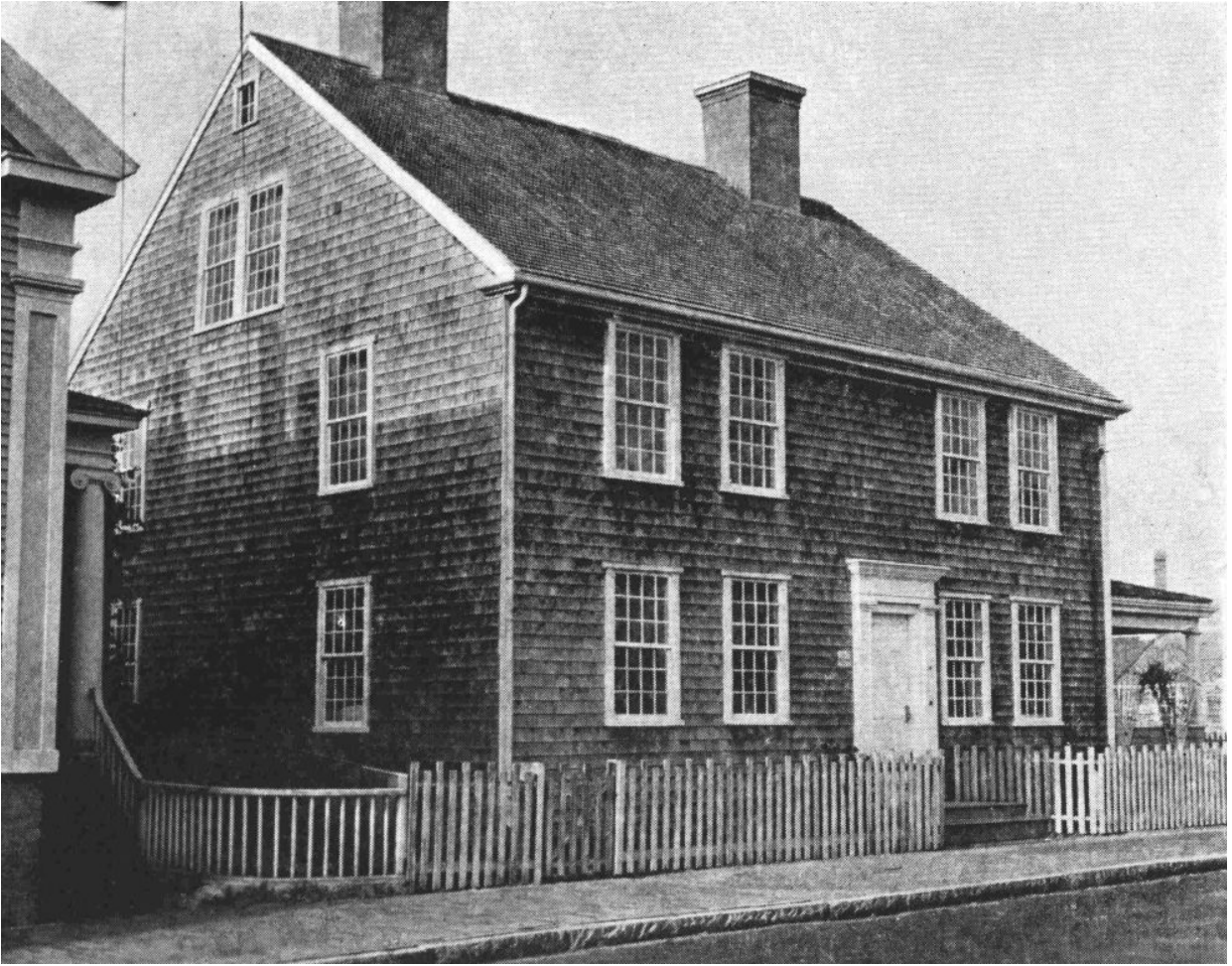
18 PINE ST.



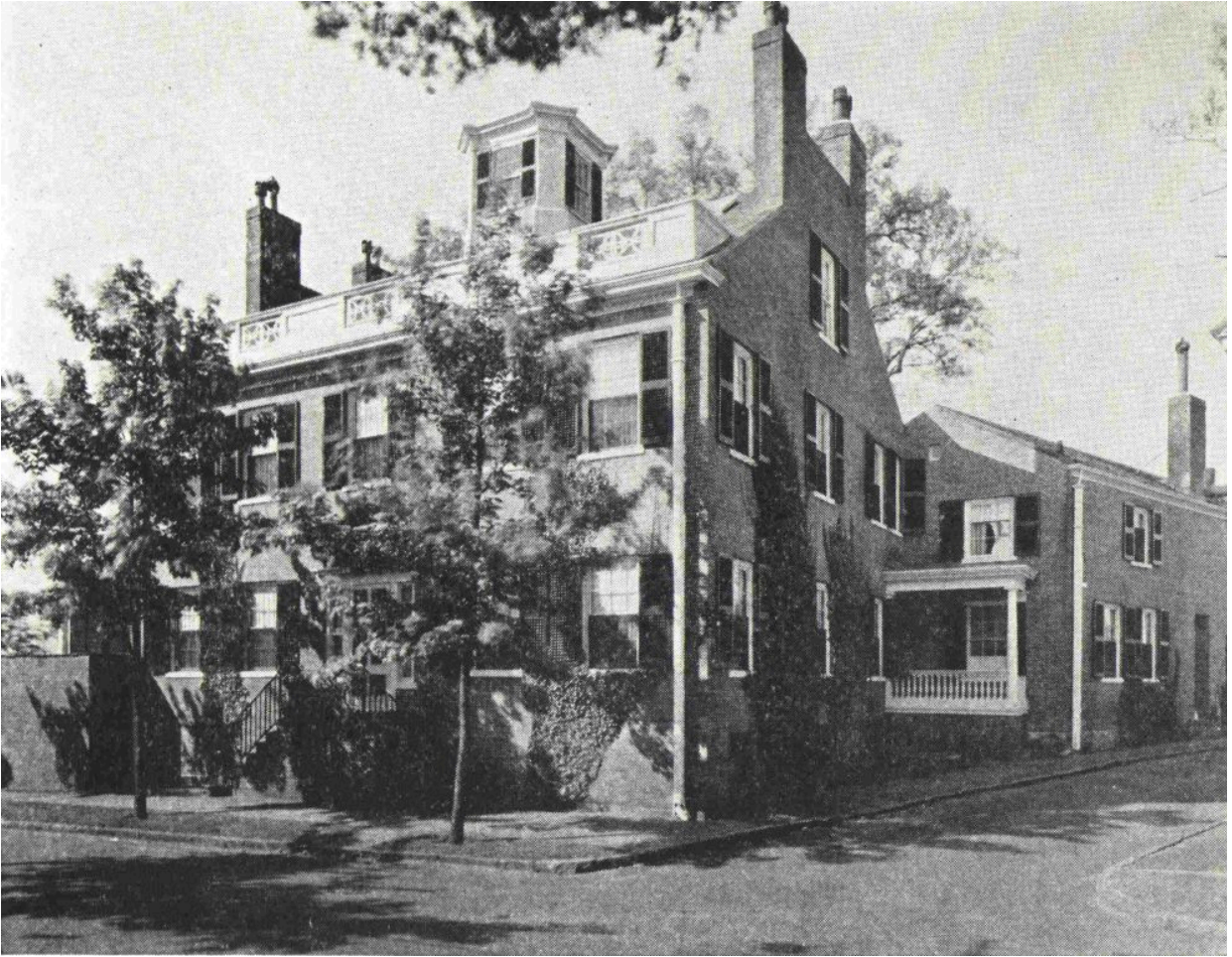
7 PLEASANT ST.



8 PLEASANT ST.



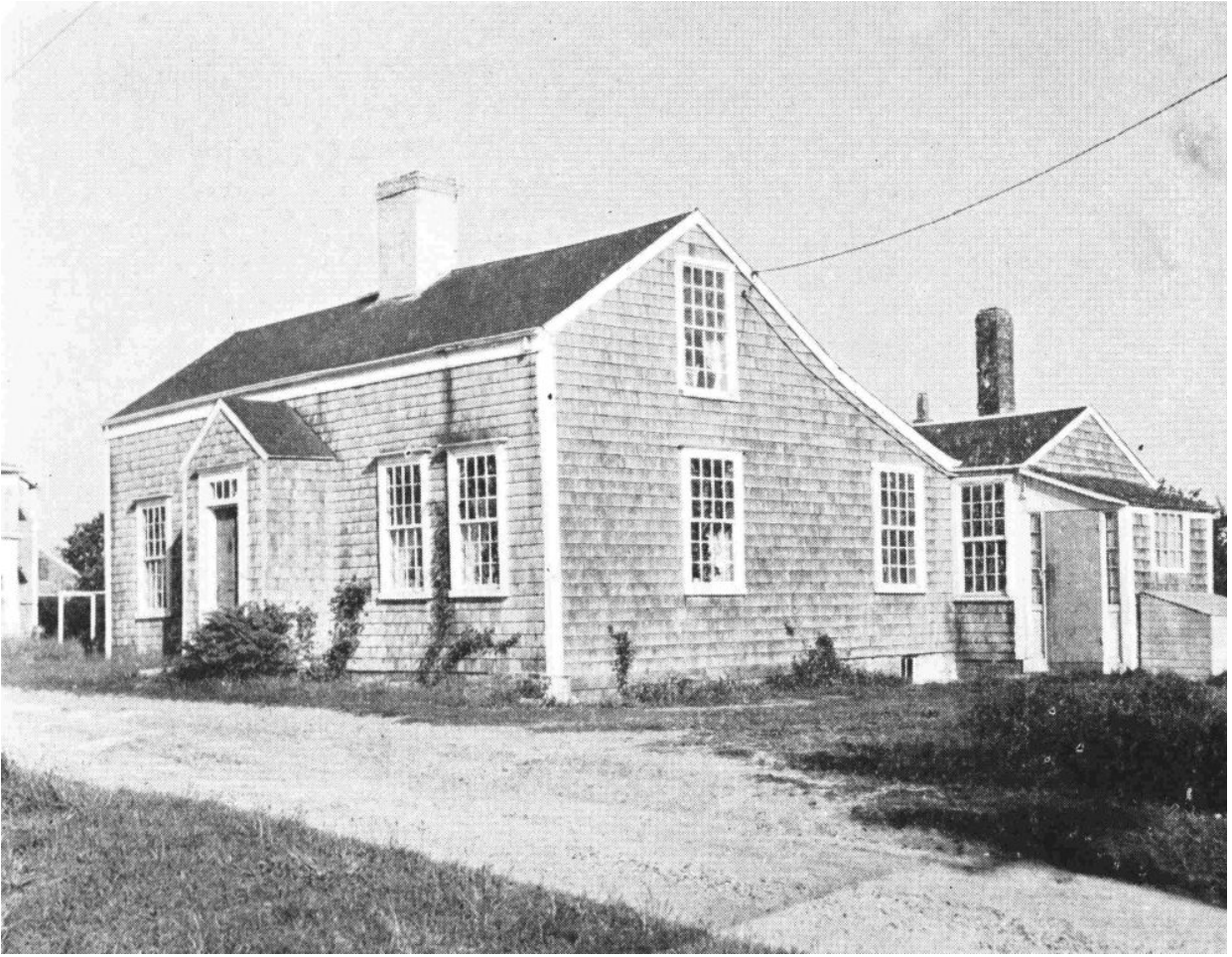
15 PLEASANT ST.



19 PLEASANT ST.



9 QUINCE ST.



2 WEST SILVER ST.



SUNSET HILL



18 UNION ST.



21 UNION ST.

DESCRIPTIONS OF NANTUCKET

The people for whom the old dwellings were built and the conditions under which they lived were responsible for the architecture.

Here are extracts from most of the older writings, and some later ones, which writings should be read in full by those interested.

1772—This is the date the author (Crevecoeur) of *Letters From An American Farmer*, by J. Hector St. John, visited this island. The “Letters” were written in English and first published in London in 1782. There was a French edition of 1784 and one of 1787. This is the earliest descriptive writing of Nantucket with which we are familiar. It consists of nearly one hundred pages, with a map, and should be read entire by all who love their old Nantucket. Subsequent articles and histories of the Island have not failed to make use of what St. John wrote.

It is best to state that M. St. Jean de Crevecoeur may not have been accurate in some details, as for instance the extent to which building frames and foundations were brought from the mainland. The writer of 1807 quoted hereinafter says of St. John’s Letters.

... “his pictures, though striking likenesses, are always flattering. Another objection is that he is frequently erroneous in minute and unimportant circumstances. He gives the contour and character of the face exactly though, as said before, in too favorable a light, but he makes strange mistakes in the sleeve of a coat or the strap of a shoe. If the reader has good nature enough to pardon these two faults, he will peruse the Letters with perpetual delight.”

The following quotations are assembled from the “Letters:”

“The Island has nothing deserving of notice but its inhabitants; here you meet with neither ancient monuments, spacious halls, solemn temples nor elegant dwellings; not a citadel nor any kind of

fortification, not even a battery to rend the air. Their rural improvements are all of the most simple and useful kind. Sherburn is the only town on the Island, which consists of about 530 houses that have been framed on the main. They are lathed and plastered within, handsomely painted and boarded without. Each has a cellar underneath, built with stones also fetched from the main. They are all of a similar construction in appearance, plain and entirely devoid of exterior or interior ornament. I observed but one which was built of bricks, belonging to Mr. —, but like the rest it is unadorned. Quayes is a small but valuable tract long since purchased by Mr. Coffin where he has erected the best house on the Island. The differences which I observed in the people are founded on nothing more than the good or ill success of their maritime enterprises and do not proceed from education. That is the same through every class: simple, useful and unadorned, like their dress and their houses. They are well acquainted with the cheapest method of procuring lumber from the Kennebeck and Penobscot Rivers. All their houses are neat, convenient and comfortable. Some of them are filled with two families, for when the husbands are at sea the wives require less house room. Those who possess the greatest fortunes at present belong to the Society of Friends. They yearly go to different parts of this continent, constantly engaged in sea affairs. Sometimes they have emigrated like bees. Some have settled on the famous river Kennebeck, clearing the heaviest timbered land in America, and instead of entirely consuming their timber as we are obliged to do, some parts of it are converted into useful articles for exportation, such as staves, boards, hoops, barrels, etc. For that purpose they keep a correspondence with their native island, and I know many of the principal inhabitants of Sherburn, who though merchants and living at Nantucket, yet possess valuable farms, on that river, from whence they draw a great part of their substance, meat, grain, firewood, etc. Yet there are not at Nantucket so many wealthy people, after having considered their great successes. The reason of this, I believe, is that their island supplies the town with little or nothing (with few families excepted). Everyone must procure what they want from the main. Here are neither Scotch, Irish nor French, as in the case in most other settlements. They are an unmixed English breed.”

1791—By Walter Folger, jun., dated Nantucket, May 21, (Mass. Hist. Soc. Coll.)

“In 1790 the whole number of inhabitants was 4619. They for the most part are a robust and enterprising people, mostly seamen and mechanics. It is no strange thing to see the same man occupy the station of a merchant, at other times that of a husbandman or of a blacksmith or of a cooper or of a number of other occupations.”

1792—By Zaccheus Macy, dated Nantucket, 15th of 5th mo. 1792 (Mass. Hist. Soc. Coll.)

“In the year 1659 Thomas Macy removed with his family from Salisbury to the west end of the island to a place called Madakit harbour. Thither came four from Martha’s Vineyard for the sake of gunning and lived with them as boarders. At that time there were near 3000 Indians on Nantucket. They were willing to sell their land and the English went on purchasing, beginning at the west end of the island.”

Further on, Mr. Macy, alluding to the then (1792) status of affairs on the island, states:

“A great many of our most substantial men, lured by the hope of large bounties, have moved from the island, some to England, some to France and others to Halifax, where they carry on the whale fishery. This is a great damage to us. If these persons had carried away with them their part of the poor it would have lightened our burden, for we now have 215 widows, of whom not thirty are able to support themselves without the assistance of friends and neighbors and some are maintained by the town. We have besides a great number of poor, but we have a considerable number of able and industrious men who carry on the whale fishery.”

1801—Josiah Quincy made a journey through the southeast parts of New England in 1801. He kept a diary which is most interesting reading. (Mass. Hist. Soc. Proc.) The following are brief quotations from it:

“The town of Nantucket appears from the harbor as large as Salem but exhibits no marks of elegance or splendour. With one or two exceptions they (the houses) are built wholly of wood and have

but two stories. By far the greater number are without paint and with those which have it, red is the predominant color. They are built generally upon the street. The almost total want of trees, houses and fences in the interior part of the island makes the road very uninteresting. Once in every two or three miles a single farmhouse appears, surrounded by half a dozen dwarf cherry trees. Such an assemblage is a wood on Nantucket, where there is not a tree of native growth. We dined with Dr. and Mrs. Easton.”

1807—A writer, under date of Aug. 1, 1807, (Mass. Hist. Soc. Coll.) states:

“The town stands on the west side of the harbour and is a mile and a half in length and a third of a mile in breadth. It contains 850 dwelling houses (including 15 at Podpis, Quayz, Squam, etc.) 63 stores, a great number of shops, besides candle works, rope walks, etc., five wharves and five windmills. The town, with exception of one or two houses, is built of wood. The houses are generally two stories in height; some of them have clapboards in front; but the greatest part of them are covered with shingles. Several of them are painted green. They are convenient buildings, but there is not much elegance in their appearance.”

Later on in his notes, he states:

“House lots in the town sell for from \$100 to \$200 a square rod; rents are low, few exceeding \$100 a year. The greatest part of the houses are owned by those who live in them. The present number of inhabitants is estimated at 6730.”

1811—Joseph Sansom, in *The Port Folio*, Jan. 1811:

“The Nantucket stores and houses are built of timber, are mostly painted red or white and are crowned by the steeples, or rather towers, of two Presbyterian meeting houses. Several new streets have been laid out in straight lines and a number of houses have been built within a year or two with ceilings of 10 feet high. This, however, is considered a piece of useless extravagance, the old-fashioned stories of eight or nine feet being generally reckoned high enough, and to spare. Every other house in this seafaring place has a lookout upon the roof or a vane at the gable end; to see what ships have arrived from sea or whether the wind is fair for the packets.”

1850 (before and after)—

Joseph E. C. Farnham was born in Nantucket in 1849. He was a keen observer of the people of the Island and their customs and wrote at considerable length “Brief Historical Data and Memories of My Boyhood Days at Nantucket.” It delightfully describes the town at the close of the whaling era.

Worth observes that “the gambrel-roofed house never attracted the attention of the Nantucket people. The few that are still standing were erected after 1750. After the Revolution, when prosperity dawned on the Island, the common type of house was the square two-story structure, with large center chimney, numerous examples of which are to be seen. The same regard for ancient houses has also led people to retain the large center chimney. While in many towns desire for increased room or for the appearance of a small chimney has led house owners to replace the old structure with one greatly inferior in size, at Nantucket the disposition has prevailed to keep without change this distinguishing mark of the 18th century construction.”

1876—Nantucket after the end of the whaling, at its lowest ebb. Read “Nooks and Corners of the New England Coast” by S. A. Drake.

1882—This date is early in a new period of prosperity due to the summer visitors. The back log and fore log of this growing and practically only sizeable remaining “industry” are now the owners and renters of houses. Visitors used to come for a “vacation” of a few days or weeks, but now they stay the season or longer. Read “Island of Nantucket, What It Was and What It Is” by E. K. Godfrey.

1924—From an article by Walter Prichard Eaton:

Individually, and in the mass, the architecture of old Nantucket was and is extraordinarily dignified in its quiet simplicity and nice proportions, and often really exquisite in its use of ornamental detail.

Nearly every other American town, once rich in Eighteenth or early Nineteenth Century architecture, has been injured by the intermingling of later buildings, but by a curious set of economic chances, old Nantucket has almost entirely escaped, and remains today architecturally much as it was

when the crest of the whaling prosperity enabled the islanders to build it more than a century ago.

Then came sophisticated moderns, and the best these moderns could do were hideous casinos, sprawling cottages with verandas stuck all over them helter-skelter, houses with broken and meaningless roof lines, windows badly spaced and without style, ornamentation without dignity, gingerbread trimmings and nothing, anywhere, that had repose, unity, beauty of outline, or even adaptability to its site.

The Puritans of Nantucket left behind no poems or plays, but to say they left behind no art is ridiculous. They left behind an entire town which is a work of art, in its way as charming and as nearly perfect as anything in the Old World, and utterly different from anything in the Old World—a unique expression. They were able to do this because, to them, art was expressed through the crafts, and every man who used a tool (which meant almost every man) was an artist.



CHIMNEYS, OLD AND NEW

Transcriber's Note

Words may have inconsistent hyphenation in the text; these were not changed. Quotation marks and final stops missing at the end of sentences and abbreviations were added. "Hits." was changed to ["Hist."](#) "... Mass. Hist. Soc. Coll...."

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